Policy platform - Election 2026

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1. Ban the most intensive and harmful forms of animal farming and fishing

The AJP proposes to implement an absolute ban on the worst animal farming and fishing practices.

We believe that all forms of animal farming and fishing should be phased out. There are steps we can take now to eliminate the cruellest and most intensive practices, helping to move towards our longer term objectives.

New Zealand's Animal Welfare Act sets out obligations on people in charge of animals (including farmed animals) to meet an animal's physical, health and behavioural needs, and to alleviate pain or distress. However in practice this does not happen. Minimum standards contained in regulations and Codes of Welfare are inadequate, often out-dated and reviewed according to the whims of Ministers, and frequently these minimum standards are not met. In addition, monitoring and enforcement is stretched - the Ministry for Primary Industries (whose main goals are productivity, export opportunities and food safety[1]) employs around 30 inspectors for more than 160 million farmed animals.[2]

We would undertake an urgent review of existing legislation, regulations and Codes of Welfare and update these to strengthen a wide-range of requirements and minimum standards. This would result in the following activities being banned:

- Intensive winter grazing (including feedlots and permanent indoor housing systems)
- Breeding fast-growing chickens
- Intensive animal farming
- Live exports and long-haul animal transport
- Mutilations
- Bottom and conventional trawling

For more detail on steps the AJP would take to raise standards for farmed animals, see our policies on Protecting the Rights of Farmed Animals and Ensuring the Welfare and Protection of Marine Life.

The AJP believes there is no place in our society for intensive animal farming and industrial fishing and that these activities should be banned with urgency. This will be a critical step in the transition to a plant-based economy, and will result in less animal suffering.

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[1] Ministry for Primary Industries. https://www.mpi.govt.nz/about-mpi/

[2] Neal, T. (15 July, 2023). *Animal cruelty: Ageing farmers' struggles linked to mistreatment of animals.* The New Zealand Herald. https://www.nzherald.co.nz/nz/animal-cruelty-ageing-farmers-struggles-linked-to-mistreatment-of-animals/QT4PNR5JINC6HIWEQUFOUEWHSY/

Key Objectives:

1. Review and urgently update New Zealand's Animal Welfare legislation, regulations and Codes of Welfare - see AJP Legislation and Regulation Reform for Animal Protection policy overviews.
2. Ban the cruellest and most intensive farming and fishing practices - see AJP Protecting the Rights of Farmed Animals and Ensuring the Welfare and Protection of Marine Life.

2. Strengthening the Animal Welfare Act (Sentience & Rights)

2 key policies support this

Legislative Foundations

To create a comprehensive and effective Animal Protection Policy, a new legislative framework must be established. This framework should address animal welfare, conservation, ethical treatment, and the enforcement of laws to ensure that animals are protected from cruelty and exploitation. Below is a proposed structure for legislative foundations that could guide the formulation of such a policy:

1. Define animal sentience in legislation
2. Strengthen legal protections recognising animals as sentient beings
3. Propose a new legislative framework with positive welfare obligations
4. Constitutional rights for nature: advocate for legal personhood for ecosystems and species
5. Abolish the legal classification of animals as property and grant animals legal rights

This will be achieved through dialogue, research, analysis and solutions-based reform proposals to inform legislative and policy change and to enable greater political accountability and more inclusive and just governance.

Law and policy reforms will be secured to create an animal welfare governance system that is transparent, in line with contemporary science and public expectations, and focuses on the wellbeing and protection of animals. These reforms in New Zealand will have the potential to set a precedent for the creation of large-scale change globally.

Sentience

The acknowledgement of animals as sentient in an amendment to the Animal Welfare Act 1999 (the "Act") in 2015 was the first of its kind in a common law jurisdiction. However, its location in the long title is telling – it simply states what the Act is about and is not defined or incorporated into the offence sections. The New Zealand Government has openly stated it is a "symbolic" change only and creates no legal or enforceable responsibility.[3]

Property

Domestic and wild animals are extremely vulnerable members of New Zealand society, and therefore require stringent legal protection. They are entitled to the same level of protection and

[3] Ferrere, M.B. R. (2022). *The (Symbolic) Legislative Recognition of Animal Sentience,* 28 Animal L. Rev. 117 Available at: https://lawcommons.lclark.edu/alr/vol28/iss1/6

rights under the law as humans and it is the antithesis of social justice that their vulnerability is not adequately legally protected.

Currently classed as the property of humans, animals have no legal rights, and therefore require AJP's advocacy, to ensure that they receive the full protection of the law.

Interim measures, while we work towards legislative change, include:

- Communication with politicians to secure reform commitments, writing submissions and reports to Select Committees, the National Animal Welfare Advisory Committee (NAWAC) and the National Animal Ethics Advisory Committee (NAEAC) on Acts, Regulations, Codes of Animal Welfare and other laws and policies affecting animals
- Reviewing current animal welfare laws and providing proposals to ensure modern animal welfare policies and legislation, using available "best practice" models, and internationally appropriate precedents as guidance
- Drafting national strategies, regulations and/or codes of practice as necessary
- Developing deterrent penalties and more effective enforcement systems
- Developing educational materials for politicians and the public

Legislation and Regulation Reform for Animal Protection

AJP supports legislation and regulation that prioritises the well-being, protection and rights of animals as sentient beings, ensuring they are not subjected to exploitation, harm or cruelty. It is imperative that animal welfare and protection legislation is adequately resourced and equipped with robust compliance monitoring, appropriate penalties and regulatory enforcement capabilities.

Animal welfare legislation should be drafted with the sole intention of recognising animal sentience and protecting animals, without influence from industries that profit from their exploitation. The principles enshrined in the Animal Welfare Act 1999 must be enforceable, without loopholes that allow industries to evade responsibility by self-regulation. Until adequate animal protection legislation is in place, AJP will also campaign to remove and prohibit exemptions and inconsistencies that allow animal cruelty to occur (for example, codes of practice for the "welfare" of farmed animals).

AJP supports a legal framework that reflects a societal commitment to valuing, protecting and respecting animals, fostering responsible and compassionate treatment in all contexts and industries. Without stringent, and enforceable, legal protection, animals remain vulnerable to cruelty and exploitation, their welfare jeopardised by profit-driven motives. Empowering and resourcing authorities to share information and enforce legislation and regulations is essential, ensuring individuals and organisations are held accountable for infringements. Championing animal-centric legislation paves the way to a more just and humane society where positive animal welfare[4] is legally recognised and animals are granted by the law the dignity and protection they deserve.

Animal welfare has become a global concern, which first requires adequate regulation at a national level.

There is an urgent need to overhaul New Zealand's animal welfare governance system to enable a paradigm shift in the value of animals and human responsibility towards them.[5] It is crucial that improved animal welfare and protection is prioritised by legislative reform and strengthened regulatory enforcement to avoid ongoing exploitation and harm at human hands.

[4] A scientific network entitled 'Laying the foundations for positive animal welfare' has been established to advance its scientific understanding (https://LIFTanimalwelfare.eu/). This network comprises more than 330 scientists from 42 countries. The resulting definition is "Positive animal welfare is defined as the animal flourishing through the experience of predominantly positive mental states and the development of competence and resilience" https://royalsocietypublishing.org/doi/epdf/10.1098/rsbl.2024.0382.

[5] Animal Protection Index (2020). Despite often being lauded as a leader in animal welfare and protection, New Zealand has a very low ranking in global animal welfare indices: https://api.worldanimalprotection.org/country/new-zealand

A Kantar Poll conducted nationwide in April 2023 showed that the welfare or treatment of animals is extremely, or very, important to three in four New Zealanders.[6]

A Horizon Research poll conducted nationwide in June 2023 shows that 90% of New Zealanders believe it is important to protect the welfare of animals farmed in New Zealand and 71% agree that the Government should do more to promote greater awareness of farmed animal welfare internationally.[7]

Purpose and Objectives of the Animal Protection Policy

AJP advocates for a new legal framework that recognises animals' right to live without suffering harm from humans and ensures that their lives and well-being are protected by the advancement of New Zealand's legal system.

The core purpose of the animal protection policy is:

- To safeguard the welfare and well-being of animals
- To promote humane treatment of animals in all sectors (agriculture, entertainment, research, etc.)
- To reduce instances of animal cruelty, neglect, and exploitation
- To foster public awareness and ethical responsibility regarding animal rights
- To protect endangered species and their habitats

AJP opposes all exploitation of animals and advocates for their ethical treatment in all human-animal interactions. We stand against all practices that subject animals to stress and/or harm. Our vision is for a society that places value on the well-being of animals and prohibits all practices that exploit or harm them.

Our advocacy entails the development and promotion of policies that end harmful practices and legally protect animals. Holistically, AJP policies promote a vision of a world where animals can thrive in ways that respect their inherent needs and behaviours.

Key Objectives

1. Appoint a dedicated Commissioner for Animals, responsible for overseeing the implementation, monitoring and enforcement of animal welfare and protection laws, to coordinate and lead animal protection efforts (see separate policy *Commissioner for Animals)*.
2. Abolish the classification of animals as property and introduce consistent legislation that defines and acknowledges animal sentience, ensuring legal protection from harm

[6] Press Release: SAFE for Animals. (2023, September 19). *Political Parties Neglect Animal Welfare, Survey Reveals.* https://www.scoop.co.nz/stories/PO2309/S00145/political-parties-neglect-animal-welfare-survey-reveals.htm
[7] HorizonPoll incorporating ShapeNZ. (2023). https://www.horizonpoll.co.nz/page/675/80-say-impo_

3. While uniform animal protection laws are being developed, campaign for the removal and prohibition of exemptions or ambiguities that enable cruelty to animals, such as Codes of Practice for the supposed “welfare” of farmed animals
4. Promote collaboration between law enforcement agencies to combat animal abuse and its links to interpersonal violence.
5. Apply import or sales restrictions on animal products sourced from outside New Zealand that do not meet the farmed animal welfare standards applied to domestic production.[8]
6. Advocate for the creation and implementation of an international treaty on animal rights

[8] Animal Policy International (2024). *Closing the Welfare Gap: Why New Zealand Must Apply Its Animal Protection Standards to Imports*. https://www.animalpolicyinternational.org/closing-the-welfare-gap

3. AJP Overview for a Plant-Based Economic Transition

The AJP is committed to transitioning Aotearoa New Zealand to a wholly plant-based economy, where animal farming has been eliminated and no animals are used for economic gain. We acknowledge the role of Māori as tangata whenua (people of the land) and recognise the importance of kaitiakitanga, manaakitanga, and tino rangatiratanga in shaping a just transition. This transformation must be guided by partnership with iwi and hapū, respecting mātauranga Māori and supporting Māori economic aspirations through sustainable land-use practices. We want to create a more prosperous, sustainable and secure economy that is underpinned by compassion for all.

A transformation approach is required. We recognise that our current economic model is deeply reliant on the exploitation of animals for food, other products and exports. And that for many New Zealanders, including both Māori and Pākehā, have strong cultural and historical ties to animal farming. For Māori, these ties are often rooted in whakapapa and a deep ancestral relationship with the land, while for Pākehā, the connection has developed more recently through settler-colonial history and generations of farming. Understanding these different histories is essential as we navigate a just transition away from animal-based systems.

However, our current agricultural model has significant environmental impacts, including biodiversity loss, freshwater degradation and greenhouse gas emissions, while also inflicting unnecessary suffering on millions of sentient beings. It is also inherently risky as an on-going economic strategy, as environmental tipping points, new technologies, consumer preferences, societal concerns and changes in global trade threaten to reduce long term demand for animal products alongside increasing regulatory burdens. New Zealand is currently in a ‘chaos and emergence’ phase where existing systems are being questioned and new alternatives are emerging.[9]

We appreciate transitioning to a plant-based economy will take time, and that to be sustainable it must happen alongside support for farmers and the development of attractive and affordable alternatives for both farmers and consumers alike. There are, however, steps we can take now that will make a huge positive impact. These include banning factory farming, tougher laws, regulations and enforcement mechanisms, supporting farm livelihood transitions, engaging with Māori leadership, supporting innovation in food tech, and promoting and incentivising more compassionate and healthy dietary choices. He ara kai pai ake mō te tinana, te wairua me te taiao (healthier and more sustainable food pathways for the body, spirit, and environment).

Shifting to a plant-based economy is the single most impactful change we can make to reduce animal suffering whilst also addressing many of our most urgent economic, social and

[9] Klerkx, L., Turner, J., & Percy, H. (2022, December 28) *Navigating the rapids of agrifood systems transformation: reflections on Aotearoa New Zealand’s emerging mission oriented agrifood innovation system.* Taylor & Francis Online. https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/00779954.2022.2158489

environmental challenges. Our vision is for a radically different economy. Our policy focuses on practical steps that can be implemented now to make this future possible.

Four overarching objectives

Our policy for transitioning to a plant-based economy is focussed on shifting away from animal agriculture and animal-based foods, and replacing these with sustainable and compassionate alternatives. It is centered around four objectives, each supported by specific proposals:

1. **Increase consumption of plant-based foods**. Use a variety of policy levers to increase consumption and market demand for healthier, kinder, more sustainable food options that align with kai ora (healthy food) principles
2. **Use land and water sustainably and compassionately**. Use regulation and incentives to shift from animal to plant-based farming and other sustainable land and water uses.
3. **Support farmers, workers and communities to transition**. Engage and collaborate to support a fair and inclusive transition with economic opportunities for all.
4. **Develop long-term economic alternatives**. Invest in new technologies, products and markets- to replace animal farming and provide prosperity and jobs.

To achieve these objectives, the Government should urgently develop a National Action Plan to implement the proposals set out in this document. While animal agriculture currently remains economically significant, there are both environmental and market pressures that suggest the potential for transition. Given this context, transitioning to a plant-based economy should be a national priority and the Government must play a critical role in making this happen.

The ‘value’ of animal exploitation to New Zealand’s economy

Despite its well documented negative impacts, animal agriculture occupies a prominent position in New Zealand's economy and national identity. While agriculture is often described as the foundation of New Zealand's economic prosperity, contributing to GDP, exports and employment, the combined agricultural and fishing sectors represent approximately just 5% of GDP.

The dairy sector accounts for 3% of this (>$11BN) and provides an estimated 55,000 jobs. Dried milk powder is one of our most significant export commodities, with the dairy export trade earning around $1 in every $4 of New Zealand’s foreign exchange income.[10] However, the expansion of dairy farming has led to economic vulnerabilities, including significant trade imbalances and a high reliance on imports. It has also resulted in environmental challenges, particularly regarding water quality.

Shifting away from these industries will be a significant challenge. New Zealand's agricultural identity, established during colonisation as the dairy farm of the British Empire, continues to shape its global economic position and national politics. A just transition requires redressing these injustices by prioritising Māori leadership in land-use decision-making, ensuring economic benefits are equitably distributed, and honoring Māori aspirations for self-determined food and land systems. The close alignment between agricultural and state interests has historically been

[10] For an industry perspective see: Sense Partners. (2023). *Dairy’s economic contribution to New Zealand.* https://www.dairynz.co.nz/media/0oibxesz/solid-foundations-4-september-2023.pdf

reflected in strong rural sector representation in Parliament.[11] This deep institutional and political entrenchment, combined with significant industry influence over policy making, means that developing viable economic alternatives will require substantial time, innovation and investment.

It is imperative that we begin the transition to a plant-based economy with urgency. This is critical not only to protect the environment, our health, and millions of sentient beings, but also for our long-term economic prosperity. As consumers change dietary habits; as countries such as China prioritise food independence; and as innovation in food technology increasingly provides cruelty-free alternatives, there is a very real possibility that future market demand for New Zealand's animal products will decline. Shifting away from animal agriculture offers opportunities to diversify, build resilience, food security, and secure long-term economic prosperity.

Impacts on animals

Millions of farmed animals are slaughtered in New Zealand every year. Data from StatsNZ reveals that around 27 million 'livestock' were killed in 2023, including 21 million lambs and sheep, 4.6 million cows and 600,000 pigs, heifers, bulls, steers and calves. In addition, it is estimated that 120 million chickens are slaughtered annually.[12] Between 953 million to 5.94 billion wild-fish were killed for food (2016, Our World in Data), this estimate does not include unrecorded fish capture, such as bycatch and discards. Farmed fish, including salmon, mussels and oysters are killed in their hundreds of millions annually.

However, the impact on farmed animals cannot be captured by numbers alone. Poor conditions and cruel practices are widespread. New Zealand's animal welfare laws are inadequate even when they are adhered to, but in practice we know that legal minimum standards are often not met - with negative consequences for the sentient beings that are powerless to resist. Whilst high welfare standards are better than low / no standards, ultimately the only ethically justifiable course of action is to phase out animal farming altogether.

Impacts on the environment

Animal farming is a major driver of climate change. Globally it is responsible for between 10% and 20% of global GHG emissions, and it is one of the leading causes of deforestation.[13] 48.6% of New Zealand's total emissions in 2022 came from sheep and cattle, of which 25.7% was from dairy cattle, 12.4% from sheep and 10.5% from beef cattle.[14] The inefficiency of producing food through animals also means that shifting to plant-based foods has the potential to release large tracts of land for ecosystem restoration and reforestation - critical parts of the solution to climate

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[11] Federated Farmers. (2023, November 1). *From the back paddock to the Beehive.* Farmers Weekly. https://www.farmersweekly.co.nz/politics/from-the-back-paddock-to-the-beehive/

[12] See: Figure.NZ. (1982-2024 in Millions) https://figure.nz/chart/3MTXwpL6IC7HriMp (sheep), https://figure.nz/chart/sTN0HlwsCBAbVCFz (livestock), https://figure.nz/chart/MvEo5sIoSRn18Ofd (cattle), https://figure.nz/chart/tkWQS2fpbiLVpF7N (pigs) and https://animalsaotearoa.org/learn/how-chickens-suffer-at-slaughter/ (chickens).

[13] Blaustein-Rejto, D., & Gambino, C. (2023, March 20). Estimates vary depending on a variety of assumptions and methodological approaches. *Livestock Don't Contribute 14.5% of Global Greenhouse Gas Emissions.* The Breakthrough Institute. https://thebreakthrough.org/issues/food-agriculture-environment/livestock-dont-contribute-14-5-of-global-greenhouse-gas-emissions

[14] New Zealand Agricultural Greenhouse Gas Research Centre (2024). *Race on to reduce emissions from New Zealand livestock.* Accessed April 2025. https://www.nzagrc.org.nz/news-and-events/race-on-to-reduce-emissions-from-new-zealand-livestock/

change.[15] In New Zealand around half of all land is used for agriculture, the vast majority of which is for grazing.[16]

Animal farming also has severe effects on rivers and waterways - degrading ecosystems, killing animals and reducing water quality. Many Māori communities bear the brunt of these effects, with degraded rivers, pollution, and land-use pressures disproportionately affecting Māori land and resources. In New Zealand the Ministry for the Environment has estimated that 95% of waterways whose catchments included areas of farmland exceed guideline values for water turbidity or dissolved nutrients; and that 24% of total river length in those catchments had E. coli levels that were greater than would be expected under natural conditions.[17] Algal growth in streams and rivers - caused by fertiliser runoff - is widespread, leading to impairment of water for swimming, drinking and fish and other wildlife.

Impacts on human health

The rise in consumption of animal products over the past decades correlates with increasing rates of chronic disease in New Zealand and globally. Research demonstrates clear associations between high consumption of animal products and adverse health outcomes. Specifically, red and processed meat consumption is linked to increased risk of colorectal cancer, with the World Health Organisation classifying processed meat as a Group 1 carcinogen, alongside alcohol and tobacco.[18] High consumption of animal products is associated with increased risk of cardiometabolic diseases, certain cancers, and all-cause mortality.[19]

Conversely, scientific evidence consistently shows that plant-based diets play both preventative and therapeutic roles in managing major chronic conditions including cardiovascular disease, type 2 diabetes, obesity, and certain cancers. Studies indicate that replacing animal-based foods (such as red meat, processed meat, eggs, and dairy) with plant-based alternatives (including legumes, nuts, whole grains, and olive oil) improves cardiometabolic health outcomes.[20]

Plant-based diets are demonstrated to be safe and nutritionally adequate across all life stages, from pregnancy and lactation through to elderly care, when appropriately planned.. Beyond individual health benefits, transitioning toward plant-based agriculture could significantly reduce the growing burden on our healthcare system. Shifting toward predominantly plant-based diets is not only feasible but could substantially improve public health outcomes, reduce healthcare

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[15] For a summary of animal agriculture and global land use see: Poore & Nemeck (2018) *Reducing food's environmental impacts* and https://ourworldindata.org/global-land-for-agriculture.

[16] Environmental Health Intelligence New Zealand. (2021). *Agricultural land use*. [Factsheet] https://ehinz.ac.nz/assets/Surveillance-reports/Released_2021/Agricultural-Land-Use_FA.pdf

[17] Ministry for the Environment. (2020). Our freshwater 2020, report: ME 1490. https://environment.govt.nz/publications/our-freshwater-2020/

[18] World Health Organization. (2015). *Cancer: Carcinogenicity of the consumption of red meat and processed meat.* https://www.who.int/news-room/questions-and-answers/item/cancer-carcinogenicity-of-the-consumption-of-red-meat-and-processed-meat

[19] Van Dooren, C. et al.(2018). *White paper: Towards a more plant-based diet* https://mobiel.voedingscentrum.nl/Assets/Uploads/voedingscentrum/Documents/Professionals/Overig/White%20paper%20-%20Towards%20a%20more%20plant-based%20diet%20-%20Dutch%20Nutrition%20Centre.pdf

[20] Neuenschwander, M., Stadelmaier, J., Eble, J. et al. (2023). Substitution of animal-based with plant-based foods on cardiometabolic health and all-cause mortality: a systematic review and meta-analysis of prospective studies. BMC Med 21, 404. https://doi.org/10.1186/s12916-023-03093-1

costs by $11 to 22 billion,[21] and help address ethnic health inequities,[22] as Māori and Pacific communities bear a disproportionate burden of diet-related diseases. This transition presents an opportunity to move from a healthcare system focused on treating chronic diseases to one centered on prevention through dietary change.

In a plant-based economy, the risk of food-borne illnesses, pandemics and antibiotic resistance would be significantly reduced, creating a safer and more resilient food system. Industrial animal agriculture is a breeding ground for dangerous pathogens, with c. ramped, unsanitary conditions allowing bacteria and viruses—such as Salmonella, E. coli, and even pandemic-causing influenza strains[23]—to spread rapidly. Additionally, the heavy use of antibiotics in livestock farming fuels the rise of antibiotic-resistant superbugs, threatening human medicine.[24] By shifting to a plant-based food system, we remove these high-risk environments, reducing the likelihood of zoonotic disease outbreaks and preserving the effectiveness of life-saving antibiotics. A future built on plant-based foods is not only kinder to animals and the planet but also crucial for global public health.

Other voices for change

The AJP is not alone in advocating for a transition to a plant-based economy.

The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change has said that shifting to more sustainable diets is a major opportunity to reduce global GHG emissions, with a theoretical global shift to wholly plant-based diets saving up to 8Gt CO_2e p/a (~13% of total current global emissions).[25]

At the national level some countries are now implementing measures to support a reduction in animal based foods. For example the Netherlands has a goal to reduce meat consumption by 50% by 2030,[26] in October 2023 the Danish government published a national plant-based action plan with its strategy to transition Denmark towards a richer plant-based diet and boost plant-protein production[27] [28] and France's Climate and Resilience law (2021) encourages school canteens to serve more vegetarian meals.[29]

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[21] Healthier lives (Sustainable NZ Kai project). (2024). *Modelled methods and impacts of shifts in dietary intake*. https://healthierlives.co.nz/wp-content/uploads/Modelling-methods-and-theoretical-scenarios.pdf

[22] Cleghorn C, Nghiem N, & Ni Mhurchu, C. (2022). *Assessing the Health and Environmental Benefits of a New Zealand Diet Optimised for Health and Climate Protection*. Sustainability, 14(21):13900. https://doi.org/10.3390/su142113900

[23] Zhang, T., Nickerson, R., Zhang, W., Peng, X., Shang,Y., Zhou, Y., Luo, Q., Wan, G., & Cheng, Z. (2024). *The impacts of animal agriculture on One Health—Bacterial zoonosis, antimicrobial resistance, and beyond*. One Health, vol 18 https://doi.org/10.1016/j.onehlt.2024.100748

[24] Pandey S, Doo H, Keum GB, Kim ES, Kwak J, Ryu S, Choi Y, Kang J, Kim S, Lee NR, Oh KK, Lee JH, Kim HB. (2024). *Antibiotic resistance in livestock, environment and humans: One Health perspective.* J Anim Sci Technol, 66(2):266-278. doi: 10.5187/jast.2023.e129.

[25] IPCC (2019) *Climate Change and Land: an IPCC special report*

[26] New Zealand Foreign Affairs and Trade. (2024). *Rise in plant-based proteins in the Netherlands and Spain.* https://www.mfat.govt.nz/en/trade/mfat-market-reports/rise-in-plant-based-proteins-in-the-netherlands-and-spain-april-2024

[27] Ministry of Food, Agriculture and Fisheries of Denmark. (2023). *Danish action plan for plant-based food.* https://en.fvm.dk/Media/638484294982868221/Danish-Action-Plan-for-Plant-based-Foods.pdf

[28] Green Queen. (2024). *Denmark Invests $2.1B to Speed Up Green Transition* https://www.greenqueen.com.hk/denmark-green-research-innovation-fund-plant-based-agriculture-climate-change/?utm_source=green-queen-future-food-weekly.beehiiv.com&utm_medium=newsletter&utm_campaign=would-you-drink-watermelon-seed-milk-future-food-weekly

[29] The Vegan review. (2021). *France adopts climate law that reduces meat on school menus.* https://www.theveganreview.com/france-climate-change-resilience-law-reduces-meat-school-menus/

At a regional level, California's Plant-Based School Lunch Act (2022) provides additional reimbursements to schools serving plant-based meals, incentivising more plant-based options in school cafeterias[30] and New York City hospitals offer plant-based dishes as the default option since 2022.[31] Most large schools and universities in the U.S., France and Germany offer regular meatless meal options.[32]

Civil society initiatives, such as the Plant Based Treaty,[33] provide ways for individuals, organisations and communities to shift towards plant-based diets. The AJP supports the Plant Based Treaty, and became a signatory in 2024.

A Treaty-Based Approach to Economic Transition

The AJP recognises that the transition to a plant-based economy must be grounded in Te Tiriti o Waitangi me ngā mātāpono o te ao Māori (the Treaty of Waitangi and Māori worldviews), ensuring that Māori are central partners in shaping Aotearoa's future. By integrating mātauranga Māori, supporting indigenous food sovereignty, and investing in Māori-led agricultural transformation, we can create a truly sustainable, compassionate and equitable economy for all. This includes recognising practices such as maramataka (Māori lunar planting cycles) and māra kai (community food gardens) as part of broader environmental restoration and food sovereignty initiatives.

The Government has a critical role in ensuring this transition is just, inclusive, and reflective of Aotearoa's unique bicultural identity. By working in genuine partnership with Māori, we can create an economic model that protects the environment, enhances well-being, and upholds the principles of Te Tiriti o Waitangi.

"Me whai kia whakamana te reo Māori, mātauranga Māori, me ngā tikanga tuku iho i roto i tēnei huringa ōhanga. **(We must ensure that te reo Māori, Māori knowledge, and customary practices are upheld throughout this economic transition.)**

[30] California Legislative Information. (2019). AB-479 *School meals: plant-based food and milk options: California School Plant-Based Food and Beverage* Program. https://leginfo.legislature.ca.gov/faces/billVersionsCompareClient.xhtml?bill_id=201920200AB479&cversion=20190AB47999INT#:~:text=A%20single%20meal%20with%20both,reimbursement%20amounts%20in%20quarterly%20installments.

[31] NYC Health + Hospitals. (2023). *NYC Health + Hospitals Now Serving Culturally-Diverse Plant-Based Meals As Primary Dinner Option for Inpatients at All of Its 11 Public Hospitals.* https://www.nychealthandhospitals.org/pressrelease/nyc-health-hospitals-now-serving-plant-based-meals-as-primary-dinner-option-for-inpatients-at-all-of-its-11-public-hospitals/

[32] Rethink Priorities. (2024). *Shallow overview of institutional plant-based meal campaigns in the US and Western Europe.* https://rethinkpriorities.org/research-area/plant-based-meal-campaigns-in-the-us-western-europe/

[33] Plant Based Treaty. (n.d.). https://plantbasedtreaty.org/ Accessed April 2025.

Make plant-based foods the default option for public institutions

The AJP proposes to increase the availability of plant-based foods in schools, hospitals and other public institutions and events - by making nutritious plant-based foods the default option.

At the current time our public institutions offer little in the way of alternatives to animal-based foods, even in settings like hospitals where health and nutrition alone should be a strong motive for change. Increasing the availability and visibility of delicious plant-based foods is a low-cost high-impact way of increasing demand for these products and supporting more sustainable, healthy and compassionate consumer choices. This in turn has the potential to create a ripple effect beyond public institutions by influencing broader community eating habits and private organisations.

Similar initiatives have been implemented with success elsewhere in the world. For example in New York in 2022 plant-based meals were made the default option across 11 public hospitals. The initiative was introduced to address both health and environmental objectives. By early 2024 over 1.2 million plant-based meals had been served with an 80%+ satisfaction rate, and with discharged patients receiving a free booklet of plant-based recipes to try at home. This also led to an estimated 36% reduction in planet-heating greenhouse gas pollution, pointing to the contribution these initiatives can make towards organisational carbon reduction efforts.[34]

To implement these initiatives in Aotearoa, we will also encourage the use of rooftops, courtyards, and other green spaces in public institutions to create edible gardens. These gardens can supply fresh, seasonal ingredients directly to institutional kitchens - the ultimate in "farm to plate" - while also providing educational and therapeutic value. Patients, students, staff, and visitors observing or participating in these gardens may be inspired to grow food at home, creating a ripple effect beyond the institution. Globally, edible landscapes are being successfully used in hospitals,[35] schools,[36] and community centres[37] to reconnect people with food, promote sustainability and enhance wellbeing.
To implement these initiatives effectively, we will work with hauora Māori (Māori health providers), tohunga kai (food experts), and food suppliers to develop culturally appropriate guidelines and menus that prioritise plant-based options. We will engage with communities to cultivate buy-in and develop solutions that reflect the needs of all New Zealanders.

[34] NYC Health and Hospitals. (2024). *Hospitals Celebrates 1.2 Million Plant-Based Meals Served.* [Press Release] https://www.nychealthandhospitals.org/pressrelease/nyc-health-hospitals-celebrates-1-2-million-plant-based-meals-served/
[35] Boston Medical Centre. (2024) *Rooftop farm.* https://www.bmc.org/nourishing-our-community/rooftop-farm
[36] Edible Garden City. (n.d.). *Key projects and collaborations*. https://www.ediblegardencity.com/key-projects
[37] Piñeda, N., L. (2018, May 9). *Incredible Edible: Yorkshire town's food-growing scheme takes root worldwide.* The Guardian. https://www.theguardian.com/world/2018/may/09/incredible-edible-yorkshire-towns-food-growing-scheme-takes-root-worldwide

AJP believes that instigating plant-based food by default in public institutions is an effective low-regrets step that can be taken now and that will support a shift away from animal-based foods. It will lead to better health and environmental outcomes and reduce demand for products that cause immeasurable animal suffering.

Key Objectives:

1. Introduce plant-based menus at all public institutions and events, with plant-based food the default option (animal-based options available on request).
2. Use public procurement to increase demand for plant-based foods and reduce demand for animal-based foods.
3. Support the Plant Based Treaty.

Ensure fair and transparent labelling

The AJP proposes to mandate fair and transparent food labelling that provides information about the environmental, health and animal welfare impacts of food and drink products.

At the current time very little information is provided to consumers about the impacts of the food and drink products they buy. Even when there is strong scientific evidence - for example that processed red meats cause cancer - this is not communicated on packaging, in contrast to other harmful products like tobacco. Furthermore, many of the marketing terms used on food and drink products are not standardised (such as 'natural' and 'less dairy') - and thus can be misleading to consumers.

By introducing a new mandatory system of labelling we will ensure that consumers have access to the information they need to make more sustainable, healthier and compassionate choices. This will also support producers who achieve higher standards and help to drive a broader transformation of food supply chains.

Looking internationally, there are examples of good-practice approaches to labelling that communicate information to consumers in a simple, transparent and high impact way. For example in the UK a red-amber-green traffic light system is used to show nutritional information such as levels of salts, fats and sugars. Research has found that this type of mandatory labelling can be effective in encouraging healthier consumer choices.[38]

The AJP believes that consumers have the right to information about the health, animal welfare and environmental impacts of the food and drink products they buy, and that standardised, fair and transparent labelling has an important role to play.

Key Objectives:

1. Adopt a nutrition-based traffic-light labelling system for food and drink products.
2. Mandate the use of clear warnings of health risks where robust evidence exists e.g. cancer warnings on processed red meats as per the World Health Organisation rankings.[39]
3. Introduce greenhouse gas emission labelling on all food and drink products.
4. Develop standardised definitions and require mandatory labelling for terms such as 'vegan', 'plant-based' and related.
5. Ban the use of misleading terms such as 'less dairy'.

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[38] Song J, Brown M. K, Tan M, MacGregor G. A, Webster J, Campbell N. R. C, Trieu K, Ni Mhurchu C, Cobb L. K., & He F. J. (2021) *Impact of color-coded and warning nutrition labelling schemes: A systematic review and network meta-analysis.* PLoS Med. 2021 Oct; 18(10): e1003765

[39] Boseley, S. (2015, October 26). *Processed meats rank alongside smoking as cancer causes- **WHO***. The Guardian. https://www.theguardian.com/society/2015/oct/26/bacon-ham-sausages-processed-meats-cancer-risk-smoking-says-who

6. Mandate the clear identification of country of origin, alongside the application of import or sales restrictions on animal products that do not meet animal welfare standards applied to domestic production (see Legislation and Regulation Reform for Animal Protection).

Ensure fair and transparent labelling policy | Created April 2025

Introduce plant-based eating initiatives and improve guidelines

The AJP proposes to launch a range of plant-based, healthy eating initiatives that reduce harm to animals by promoting the consumption of healthy plant-based foods and decreasing consumption of animal-based foods. While improving public health is a valuable outcome, our primary focus is on preventing animal suffering through dietary change. These initiatives will be based on the best-available science, and communicate information in ways that promote transparency and inspire change.

New Zealand's food environment poses challenges for promoting healthier, plant-based choices. While the national dietary guidelines (last updated 2020) make some positive recommendations around plant proteins and limiting red meat, they maintain a strong emphasis on dairy products, likely reflecting industry influence. Educational initiatives like 'Garden to Table' demonstrate the potential for teaching children about growing and preparing fresh food, but operate in only a fraction of schools due to limited government funding.

Meanwhile, the public faces a constant barrage of meat-heavy fast food marketing, with major chains dominating the advertising landscape through sports sponsorship, outdoor advertising and prime-time TV spots. Children in particular are vulnerable targets for food companies, as they struggle to distinguish marketing from fact. While adults are also susceptible to marketing influence, children represent both current customers through their impact on household purchasing decisions and valuable future customers. Adults ultimately control food budgets, but research shows children significantly influence family food choices, making them strategic marketing targets despite not having direct purchasing power themselves.[40] The constant flow of advertising makes it virtually impossible for young people to avoid unhealthy food marketing, effectively normalising unhealthy consumption patterns.

We propose a three-pronged approach:

First, we will launch public media campaigns to build awareness about the health benefits of plant-based foods and the animal welfare concerns associated with animal products. These campaigns will disseminate recipes and information on how to cook nutritious plant-based meals, highlight ethical issues with animal-based foods, and reflect the diversity of New Zealand society and current health inequalities.

Second, we will review and update New Zealand's dietary guidelines to align with the latest science, including the negative impacts of many animal-based foods. We will ensure it includes guidelines for wholly plant-based diets and clearly articulates the evidence of the benefits these can bring. In recent years many countries have amended their dietary guidelines to increasingly

[40] Knellera, K., Garton, K., Exeter, D. J., & Egli,V. (2024, May 7). *Mapping the extent of unhealthy food adverts around schools in Tāmaki Makaurau/Auckland.* Taylor & Francis Online.
Vol 20, Issue1, Pg 65-82. https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/1177083X.2024.2344510#abstract

recognise the benefits of shifting away from traditional meat and dairy heavy diets[41]. For example, Canada's 2019 food guide combined meat into a broader protein category and promoted water over cow's milk, and the USA revised it's dietary guidelines (2025) to list pulses and beans as proteins and not vegetables.[42]

Third, we will support educational programmes which increase knowledge and experience with plant-based nutrition and cuisine. This could include, for example, expanding 'Garden to Table'[43] programmes in schools which teach children about growing, preparing and cooking plant-based foods and partnering with Māori educators to deliver culturally relevant nutrition education about plant-based eating and traditional food systems in schools and marae. By funding facilitators, coordinators and resources, we will encourage young people to develop healthy and sustainable food habits. For older learners we will support training programmes for chefs to develop the know-how to cook delicious, nutritious plant-based meals.[44]

The AJP believes that there is a huge opportunity to positively engage children and citizens across New Zealand's diverse communities to encourage healthy plant-based eating. This will also lead to much more sustainable and compassionate diets.

Key Objectives:

1. Launch public media campaigns about the health benefits of plant-based foods.
2. Update New Zealand's dietary guidelines and review the panel of experts engaged in this activity.
3. Expand 'Garden to Table' programmes in schools and plant-based cooking know-how in post-school training.
4. Engage with medical practitioners to:
    a. update and expand plant-based nutrition and health with curricula
    b. hold conferences to enable continuous education on the role of wholesome and nutrition and health.[45]
5. Implement comprehensive restrictions on the marketing of unhealthy animal-based food and beverages.

Introduce plant-based eating initiatives and improve guidelines policy | Created April 2025

[41] Mridul, A. (2024, Dec 3). *To improve public and planetary health, Finland has encouraged a transition from meat-heavy diets to plant-based proteins in its revised dietary guidelines.* Green Queen. https://www.greenqueen.com.hk/finland-food-based-dietary-guidelines-red-meat-plant-based-protein/
[42] Rizzo, N., RD. (2024, Dec 12). *The 1 food you should be eating more of, according to the new, proposed US dietary guidelines.* Today. Health News. https://www.today.com/health/news/2025-us-dietary-guidelines-plant-based-foods-rcna183797
[43] https://gardentotable.org.nz/
[44] Escoffier School of Culinary Arts. (2022). *How Plant-Based Dishes Are Shaping Restaurant Menus* https://www.escoffier.edu/blog/world-food-drink/how-plant-based-dishes-are-shaping-restaurant-menus/
[45] VegMed is Europe's largest medical conference on plant-based nutrition, bringing together top experts in the field of science, health and nutrition. https://vegmed.org/

Improve access to nutritious food

The AJP proposes to improve access to nutritious food for all New Zealanders through a package of policy measures. While improving access to healthy food is a valuable outcome, our primary focus is on preventing animal suffering through dietary change. These measures will reduce costs, improve access to plant-based foods, support communities to take a lead role, and tackle inequalities and health disparities.

Food access inequities exist across Aotearoa, disproportionately affecting Māori communities.[46] Lower-income areas often have a higher concentration of fast food outlets and fewer fresh food retailers, while transport barriers and distance to supermarkets create additional challenges, particularly in rural areas.

Many communities rely on local dairies (convenience stores) which typically stock limited fresh food at higher prices. These access issues are compounded by the high cost of healthy food. Fresh fruit and vegetables are notably expensive with significant seasonal price fluctuations. Studies of healthy food baskets consistently show that eating according to nutrition guidelines requires a substantial portion of a low-income household's budget, while processed and energy-dense foods remain cheaper per calorie than fresh, nutritious options.

New Zealanders are currently not eating the recommended servings of fruit and vegetables. In 2023/24, 47.1% adults ate the recommended amount of fruit and only 9.1% ate the recommended amount of vegetables per day. For children aged 2 to 14 years the figures are 70.5% and 8.2% respectively[47].
Food insecurity, “insufficient money or resources for a healthy diet; uncertainty about the ability to obtain food; skipping meals or running out of food occasionally”,[48] can lead to an average educational achievement lag of up to four years for New Zealand teenagers,[49] and poor health outcomes and development difficulties for children, with potentially life-long impacts.[50] In 2023/24 rates of food insecurity were higher in households where children were Māori, Pacific, disabled, or living in the most deprived neighbourhoods.[51]

Healthy and sustainable food must be the most affordable options for households, and food environments need to be actively re-shaped. We will:

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[46] Public Health Advisory Committee. (2024). *Rebalancing our food system*. Wellington: Ministry of Health.
[47] Ministry of Health. (2024). *Annual Update of Key Results 2023/24: New Zealand Health Survey.* https://www.health.govt.nz/publications/annual-update-of-key-results-202324-new-zealand-health-survey
[48] Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations. (2024). *Measuring hunger, food security and food consumption.* https://www.fao.org/hunger/en
[49] Public Health Communication Centre, Aotearoa. (2024). *Food poverty for NZ teens creating an achievement lag of up to four years.* https://www.phcc.org.nz/briefing/food-poverty-nz-teens-creating-achievement-lag-four-years
[50] Mathias, S. (2024, July 31). *Around the world, food insecurity is improving. In New Zealand it’s getting worse.* The Spinoff. https://thespinoff.co.nz/kai/31-07-2024/around-the-world-food-insecurity-is-improving-in-new-zealand-its-getting-worse
[51] Ministry of Health (2024). *Annual Update of Key Results 2023/24: New Zealand Health Survey.* https://www.health.govt.nz/publications/annual-update-of-key-results-202324-new-zealand-health-survey

- Remove GST from fruits, vegetables, legumes, nuts and other core plant-based foods. This could save just over $1 billion in health costs[52] while making nutritious options more affordable and accessible.
- Create regional food hubs to aggregate and distribute plant-based foods; work with food banks to increase nutritious options; and adjust food assistance programmes to include higher allowances for purchasing plant-based foods (like in the US Government's Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Programme). These initiatives will be developed in partnership with iwi and hapū to ensure they meet the needs of Māori communities.
- Support māra kai and community gardens recognizing their importance in Māori food sovereignty. We will set aside land and fund community champions to establish and maintain these spaces. This initiative builds community, shares knowledge and provides healthy food while honoring traditional Māori food practices.[53]
- Work with retailers to create a demonstrable positive impact on the affordability and accessibility of healthy and sustainable diets. This includes addressing the supermarket duopoly to promote competition, establishing targets for meat-to-plant product ratios similar to Denmark's climate-driven approach and reforming supplier contracts that constrain product offerings in dairies. Implement restrictions on price promotions for unhealthy foods, require annual reporting on 'healthy vs unhealthy' promotion ratios, redesign store layouts to prioritise healthier options 'eye level is buy level'[54] and challenge centralisation requirements that disadvantage smaller local producers.
- Develop a National Food Strategy to set out the short, medium and long-term actions for Aotearoa to grow and consume more plant-based foods - whilst also meeting health, environmental, animal welfare and food security objectives. This strategy will be developed in partnership with Māori, ensuring that Te Tiriti principles are embedded throughout. The UK is developing a National Food Strategy in 2025.[55]

Improving nutrition would also ease pressure on our healthcare system, as fewer people would require hospital care for diet-related illnesses. Partnering with general practitioners and healthcare providers could further support this shift, ensuring more people have access to good dietary advice.

AJP advocates for more ambitious Government action to improve access to nutritious food for all New Zealanders, a stance echoed, in 2024, by the Public Health Advisory Committee recommended priority action "That those involved in our food system take action to ensure all New Zealanders have secure access to enough good food."[56] By making plant-based eating easier and affordable we can create a healthier, more sustainable country, reducing health inequalities, carbon footprint and animal suffering.

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[52] Morris,T. (2024, July 9). *Five (realistic) food policy ideas for a healthier NZ.* The Spinoff. https://thespinoff.co.nz/partner/09-07-2024/five-realistic-policy-ideas-for-a-healthier-nz

[53] Public Health Advisory Committee. (2024). *Rebalancing our food system.* Wellington: Ministry of Health. https://www.health.govt.nz/publications/rebalancing-our-food-system

[54] European Public Health Alliance. (2023). *The Illusion of Choice.* [Report]. https://epha.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/06/epha_2023_the_illusion_of_choice_report.pdf

[55] AFN Network+ (Agri-food Netzero Network). (2024) - Funded by UK Research and Innovation. *DIGEST: National Food Strategy – an update.* https://www.agrifood4netzero.net/resources/digest-national-food-strategy-an-update/

[56] Public Health Advisory Committee. 2024. Rebalancing our food system. Wellington: Ministry of Health. https://www.health.govt.nz/publications/rebalancing-our-food-system

Key Objectives:

1. Remove GST from core plant-based foods to reduce costs and increase access.
2. Create regional, community-led food hubs & adjust food assistance programmes to promote plant-based foods, developed in partnership with iwi and hapū.
3. Foster Māori-led transformation strategies to integrate indigenous perspectives and equity.[57]
4. Support community gardens and initiatives to promote healthy plant-based kai.
5. Work with retailers to improve access to affordable, nutritious food
6. Develop a National Food Strategy in partnership with Māori to take a long-term view.

Improve access to nutritious food policy | Created April 2025

[57] Klerkx, L., Turner, J., & Percy, H. (2022, December 28) *Navigating the rapids of agrifood systems transformation: reflections on Aotearoa New Zealand's emerging mission oriented agrifood innovation system.* Taylor & Francis Online. https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/00779954.2022.2158489

Ban the most intensive and harmful forms of animal farming and fishing

Reference policy focus 1

Introduce tighter standards and enforcement for agricultural pollution

The AJP seeks to address the environmental harm caused by agricultural practices while supporting farmers to transition to more sustainable and plant-based alternatives. Through a combination of regulatory reform, targeted taxation and funding mechanisms, we will create a path forward that ensures polluters pay for the damage they cause. However, this will be no substitute for action which other AJP policies will drive in order to reduce and eliminate the pollution.

Animal farming is a major polluter in Aotearoa, on land and at sea. It is responsible for a 48.6% of our planet-warming greenhouse gas emissions.[58] It also causes effluent and fertiliser run-off which is polluting our seas and rivers, making many of our waterways unfit for aquatic life as well as for human swimming and drinking. Nutrient enrichment, from fish farm releases, leads to eutrophication, promoting excessive algae growth that depletes oxygen levels and harms marine ecosystems. Additionally, animal farming has resulted in the destruction of much needed habitats for endangered species. This pollution is allowed to occur largely unchecked. Regulations are insufficiently stringent, often ignored and rarely enforced.

The huge costs from this pollution are not borne by the polluter - the animal farming industry - but by nature and society at large. This is in effect a subsidy for one of the dirtiest industries in the country.

One of the most urgent measures needed is to include agriculture into an Emissions Trading Scheme (ETS). We would adopt the Climate Change Commission's advice that the current NZ ETS should focus on fossil fuel emissions. A separate, new cap-and-trade ETS for biogenic emissions (including forestry) should be established, which lowers gross methane emissions to agreed long-term flow.[59] This should be implemented as quickly as possible. We will also set separate gross (total emissions produced) and net (emissions after offsets like forestry are

[58] Agemissions Centre. (New Zealand Agricultural Greenhouse gas research centre). (2024). *Race on to reduce emissions from New Zealand livestock*. News article - Business Desk, April, 2024. https://www.nzagrc.org.nz/news-and-events/race-on-to-reduce-emissions-from-new-zealand-livestock/

[59] Parliamentary Commissioner for the Environment (2024, May 22). *Going with the grain: Changing land uses to fit a changing landscape*. https://pce.parliament.nz/publications/going-with-the-grain-changing-land-uses-to-fit-a-changing-landscape/

considered) emissions reductions targets and reform the ETS to ensure that gross agricultural emissions are reduced, not simply netted off by forestry plantations.

To address other forms of agricultural pollution such as nitrogen run-off, the AJP proposes an urgent review and strengthening of current standards such as the National Environmental Standards for Freshwater. We will also introduce a pollution tax on pesticides, fertilisers and other relevant forms of agricultural pollution, escalating over time reducing the environmental and ethical harms associated with animal farming and ensuring a healthier environment for all forms of life. We will fund an expansion of monitoring and enforcement capabilities so that polluters are identified and held to account.

We propose to ringfence revenues from the sale of biogenic ETS credits and pollution taxes for a new Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation (FEAT). A substantial portion of increased fossil ETS auction revenue would also be directed to this fund. FEAT will support activities like farm transitions, regional land restoration, environmental restoration schemes and native reforestation.

The AJP believes that pollution from animal agriculture should not be allowed to continue unchecked. As the most intensive and harmful forms of animal farming and fishing are banned, the associated polluting will abate.

This is a transitional policy, ensuring as Aotearoa moves to a truly ‘clean and green’ land where those currently causing damage pay the full cost and in turn help a shift to more sustainable and compassionate uses of our land and water. Toitū te whenua, toitū te tangata (If the land is well, the people will be well).

Key Objectives:

1. Separate the ETS into two schemes: one for fossil fuels and another for biogenic emissions, removing the unlimited forestry offset option from the fossil fuel ETS.
2. Improve regulatory standards and introduce targeted pollution taxes that reflect the true accounting cost of environmental impacts.
3. Create a Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation from multiple revenue streams to support regional control and decision-making.
4. Ensure that Māori landholders are not disproportionately impacted by policy changes and are supported in exercising kaitiakitanga.

Provide financial incentives for good environmental practices

The AJP will support more sustainable and compassionate uses of land and water through financial incentives and regulatory reform. We will create a new Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation (FEAT) to support farm transitions, reduce pollution and harm, and protect and restore natural habitats.

At the current time there are insufficient regulatory and economic incentives for farmers, fishers and land managers to look after land and water sustainably. Initially funding for the Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation would occur by implementing the "polluter pays" principle. Income would be raised from the biogenic Emissions Trading Scheme and the true cost accounting of environmental impacts via pollution taxes. Examples of activities that will be supported through this fund include:

- Support for farmers to shift towards plant-based farming systems and other sustainable land uses (see our Farm Transition Scheme proposals).
- Tax breaks and grants for plant-based farming, including diversified, veganic farming approaches that use regenerative, permaculture and natural principles to restore soil and ecosystems, enhance food security and provide nutrient-dense foods.
- Payments for farmers who adopt practices that restore ecosystems and natural habitats, promote biodiversity, enhance soil health, reduce nutrient run-off and pesticide use, and build natural flood defences and resilience to climate change.
- Auditing and enforcement to ensure practices are enduring.
- Increased funding for marine reserves and marine habitat protection schemes.

In addition we will review and strengthen regulations to encourage the maintenance and enhancement of natural ecosystems. National Policy Statements (NPS) would continue to set the high-level policy direction, alongside National Environmental Standards, coupled with flexible compliance mechanisms that accommodate different land uses and regional conditions (Regional Policy Statements) without undermining the national goals.

Many other countries around the world have implemented schemes that offer financial incentives for better environmental outcomes in the agricultural sector. Examples include the UK's Environmental Land Management Scheme (based on the principle of "public money for public goods") and the conditionality standards and eco-schemes under the EU Common Agricultural Policy. In the Netherlands, 25 billion Euros has been budgeted to support herd reduction to address water pollution from agricultural wastes.[60] Whilst these programmes are far from perfect, they offer different models and lessons to help inform the design of schemes in New Zealand. An iterative process of policy implementation and learning is needed.

[60] Levitt, T. (2021, December 15). *Netherlands announces €25bn plan to radically reduce livestock numbers.* The Guardian. Animals farmed, Netherlands. https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2021/dec/15/netherlands-announces-25bn-plan-to-radically-reduce-livestock-numbers

The AJP believes that a transformation in the way we use our land and water is needed to support more sustainable and compassionate approaches, boost animal habitats, reduce animal suffering - all delivering wider benefits to society.

Key Objectives:

1. Create a Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation to subsidise plant-based and ecosystem-restorative farming.
2. Promote regenerative plant-based farming to rebuild soil health, restore ecosystems and protect biodiversity.
3. Offer tax credits for verified emissions reductions and biodiversity restoration.

Objective 3: Support farmers, workers and communities to transition

Introduce a farm transition scheme

The AJP proposes to create a new national scheme that provides direct support to animal farmers who wish to transition to plant farming and other economic activities. This farmer-led, government-supported initiative will build momentum and knowledge on viable approaches for diversifying beyond animal farming, while recognising and honouring the unique considerations of Māori land and agricultural practices.

At the current time there are practical, financial and cultural barriers that prevent animal farmers from diversifying their activities and moving away from animal farming.[61] Whilst there are examples in Aotearoa of farmers making positive changes, they are fighting against the tide. The system as it stands is stacked against them, legacy policies and institutional structures favour incumbent systems,[62] and current adaptation strategies often reinforce unsustainable, high-input systems.[63]

There are also knowledge gaps in terms of the most economically viable, sustainable alternatives to animal farming, both in New Zealand and elsewhere in the world, which need addressing urgently as the global food system changes.

However, this concentration into dairying in particular, is a relatively recent phenomenon. Many regions were previously much more diverse, growing crops as well as animals. Pig farming in this country is facing significant challenges as farmers struggle to comply with new regulations and compete with floods of cheap overseas pork from countries with lower animal welfare standards. Similarly, sheep farmers are confronting problems due to climate change-induced weather patterns, an aging farmer population, and decreasing value of mutton and lamb exports. The reluctance of younger generations to enter these industries—including cattle farming—represents a further challenge. These signs point to a broader decline in animal agriculture, creating both urgency and opportunity for transition. The concentration of rural production into animal agriculture means there is great opportunity for diversification in the future.

Internationally there are examples of inspiring initiatives that are helping farmers to transition. In the US, the Transformation Project provides resources and support to industrial animal farmers

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[61] Salliou, N. (2023, June 15). *Quitting livestock farming: transformation pathways and factors of change from post-livestock farmers' accounts.* Frontiers in Sustainable Food Systems. Sec. Social Movements, Institutions and Governance, Volume 7 - 2023. https://doi.org/10.3389/fsufs.2023.1122992

[62] Klerkx, L., Turner,J., & Percy, H. (2023, December 28) *Navigating the rapids of agrifood systems transformation: reflections on Aotearoa New Zealand's emerging mission oriented agrifood innovation system.* Taylor & Francis Online https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/00779954.2022.2158489

[63] Griffin,C., Wreford, A., & Cradock-Henry, N. A. (2023, February). *'As a farmer you've just got to learn to cope': Understanding dairy farmers' perceptions of climate change and adaptation decisions in the lower South Island of Aotearoa-New Zealand*. Science Direct *Journal of Rural Studies*, 98, 147-158. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jrurstud.2023.02.001

who want to shift to raising crops for human consumption. Successful case-studies include the conversion of a chicken farm to growing hemp in Texas, and the conversion of an intensive pig farm to a specialty mushroom operation in Iowa.

Our proposed farm transition scheme would learn from these international examples. It would be available to animal farmers wishing to transition as well as to existing plant farmers who are seeking additional support. It would be supported by our proposed Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation with revenue raised from agricultural emissions pricing and taxing agricultural pollution (see our 'Provide financial incentives for environmental good practice' proposal). Likely activities include:

- Farm assessments and transition plans
- Training, resources and educational materials
- Farmer-to-farmer networks and peer mentoring
- Connecting farmers with buyers and supply chains
- Financial and business planning
- Grants, loans and debt restructuring / cancellation
- Reuse of stranded assets, e.g. old meat works gaining new functions

The scheme will include a farmer-led task force, with dedicated Māori representation, to identify regulatory, technological, financial and market barriers, and work with Government to implement changes that address these barriers and unlock the investment needed for more farms to transition. The scheme will continue to develop building land-use change and bioeconomy opportunities, respect kaitiakitanga principles and cultural values while positioning Aotearoa as a leader in alternative proteins.

The AJP believes there is huge potential for farmers to lead the transition to plant-based agriculture in ways that suit each farm's specific needs and local context. We are committed to using the resources and influence of Government to help make this a reality in collaboration with farmers and the community.

Key Objectives:

1. Establish a Farm Transition Advisory Network - a multidisciplinary new farmer-led national scheme to provide direct support to animal farmers who wish to transition to plant farming or other economic activities and identify potential opportunities and barriers.
2. Support farmers through a wide-range of activities including transition planning, training and education, financial planning, grants and loans, and debt restructuring.
3. Ensure meaningful Māori participation and partnership throughout the development and implementation of the scheme.

Support for rural economies to thrive without animal agriculture

The AJP will provide support to rural communities to develop and sustain strong local economies that do not rely on animal agriculture and that are resilient to a rapidly changing global context. We propose to introduce financial and other types of support to local councils, community groups and businesses to shift towards economic activities that foster prosperity and sustainability, and that deliver a just transition to a plant-based economy.

Given the current reliance of many of New Zealand's rural communities on animal agriculture for their economic well-being, it is essential that the transition to a plant-based economy includes a proactive and locally-led approach to protecting rural economies; this would occur via the proposed Farm Transition Advisory Network. Currently the interconnected web of services creates a self-reinforcing economic ecosystem where feed suppliers, veterinary services, equipment manufacturers, pharmaceutical companies and processing facilities are all dependent on continuing intensive animal production, while also generating environmental and social externalities that are often not fully accounted for in the economics of the system.[64]

There is an opportunity to develop more diversified local economies that are resilient to global changes in climate, trade, technology and consumer demand. Potential economic opportunities include horticulture, plant-based farming for emerging market demand (e.g. hemp, oats and quinoa), plant-based food manufacturing, timber and fibre processing, tourism and energy.

We propose to establish a national rural economies programme, funded through our Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation with revenue raised from agricultural emissions pricing and taxing agricultural pollution (see our 'Provide financial incentives for environmental good practice' proposal). Likely activities funded by this Fund could include:

- Supporting local councils and Iwi to develop rural economic development plans
- Financial support for community-led initiatives and new or established businesses
- Investments in local infrastructure

Recent examples from other sectors provide useful lessons for a proactive approach to long-term economic development and a just transition. In Queenstown, an Economic Transformation and Resilience Fund supports diversification away from tourism aiming to increase economic resilience and develop higher-paying jobs.[65] In Taranaki, Transition Action Plans address how the local economy can move away from oil and gas production. These examples showcase efforts to build more resilient and diverse regional economies, reducing dependence on single industries and fostering sustainable growth across multiple sectors.

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[64] Mason, R. (2024). *Industrial Food Animal Production: How It Works And How We Resist.* Issue Lab [ACE Report]. https://www.issuelab.org/resources/43293/43293.pdf

[65] Ministry of Business, Innovation & Employment. (2021). *Queenstown Economic Transformation and Resilience Fund.* https://www.mbie.govt.nz/immigration-and-tourism/tourism/tourism-recovery/tourism-communities-support-recovery-and-re-set-plan/queenstown-economic-transformation-and-resilience-fund

The AJP believes that strong rural economies are central to a successful plant-based transition. Through a community-led approach to co-develop transition plans, with investment and support, rural areas can diversify away from animal agriculture towards more diversified economic models that are not only more compassionate, but also more resilient and prosperous.

Key Objectives:

1. Create a national programme to support the development of strong, resilient and prosperous rural economies during a transition to a plant-based economy, including targeted educational initiatives to address climate skepticism and build community support for sustainable agricultural practices.
2. Provide funding and support to local Councils, Iwi, community-led initiatives and businesses; alongside investments in local infrastructure.
3. Support crop diversification programs.

Reskill workers within, and supporting, the industrial animal system

The AJP proposes to create reskilling and training programmes for those currently working in the animal farming, processing and food industries.

In New Zealand, DairyNZ estimates that around 55,000 people are employed in the dairy industry, generating around $3.4BN in 2019. The Meat Industry Association estimates that there are over 24,000 jobs in the meat processing sector. These jobs are varied in nature but some - such as jobs in slaughterhouses - are seasonal, precarious, and involve poor working conditions and increased risk of a range of mental health issues.

As we shift away from animal agriculture towards a plant-based economy, some animal-farming related jobs will be lost and other new jobs will be created in established and emerging plant-based food and fibre industries. To ensure a just transition and maintain public support, it will be essential for Government and local Councils to take a proactive approach to ensure workers are reskilled and can access these new jobs. Cultural identities and traditions can create resistance to change,[66] solutions will also need to be mindful of this and provide attractive opportunities.

To do this, we will create comprehensive worker training and reskilling programmes developed in partnership with iwi and hapū, to honor the principle of tino rangatiratanga (self-determination). These programmes will be:

- Publicly funded and implemented flexibly to recognise the specific skills and needs of each participant.
- Available to young people who want to go directly into a career in plant-based industries.
- Designed to incorporate mātauranga Māori (Māori knowledge) and tikanga Māori (Māori customary practices) where appropriate.
- Designed to draw on learning from similar programmes from other economic transitions such as the shift from fossil to renewable energy - including comprehensive workforce mapping and a collaborative approach between government, industry and workers.

The AJP believes that a successful transition to a plant-based economy must be fair to all and that new opportunities for employment and prosperity must be provided to those who lose their jobs in the animal-farming industry. Reskilling is essential to making this happen. This transition must also uphold the principles of Te Tiriti o Waitangi and support Māori aspirations for economic development and Kaitiakitanga (environmental stewardship).

[66] Griffin, C., Wreford, A., & Cradock-Henry, N. A. (2023, February 26). *'As a farmer you've just got to learn to cope': Understanding dairy farmers' perceptions of climate change and adaptation decisions in the lower South Island of Aotearoa-New Zealand*. *Journal of Rural Studies*, 98, 147-158, Science Direct. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jrurstud.2023.02.001

Key Objectives:

1. Create reskilling programmes, developed in partnership with Māori, to support those currently working in the animal farming industry to access jobs and opportunities in plant-based sectors.
2. Support a just transition that leaves no-one behind and honors Te Tiriti o Waitangi principles.

Reskill workers within, and supporting, the industrial animal system policy | Created April 2025

Objective 4: Develop long-term economic alternatives

Identify our biggest land-use and bioeconomy opportunities

The AJP believes that the Government should convene a national process of engagement and economic research to identify New Zealand's best opportunities to diversify the economy away from animal agriculture into new land-uses, products and markets.

At the current time our Government is taking a short-sighted approach to agricultural policy. It is disproportionately influenced by the most regressive vested interests and is now weakening environmental and animal welfare standards. Rather than take a position of leadership to diversify the country's agricultural sector away from animal farming, the Government is doubling down on the status quo - an approach which is not only bad for animals and the environment but also economically risky in a world of changing technology and markets.

New Zealand's approach to land-use urgently needs to change to deal with the challenges of climate change, biodiversity loss and water quality.

To address these issues, the Government should lead a national programme to identify the most promising economic opportunities for New Zealand's bioeconomy and land-use, taking into account future market demand, market size, jobs, GDP and export potential. It should:

- Build on work undertaken by the Ministry of Business, Innovation and Enterprise in 2023 that analysed 30 economic opportunities including land-based crops such as pine nuts, hemp and bananas; water-based crops such as microalgae and seaweed; forest based products such native botanicals and medicinal mushrooms; and bioenergy, bioplastics and biochemicals.
- Investigate indigenous plant-based food as industries, such as kūmara, and other native crops, which offer opportunities for Māori-led economic development while ensuring alignment with tino rangatiratanga.
- Focus on region-specific opportunities suited to local land types, geographies, climates and cultural contexts.
- Identify the key steps the Government can take to support these opportunities - such as removing barriers, changing regulations and introducing incentives etc.
- Involve a broad process of engagement and collaboration with farmers, land managers, economists, academics, and the businesses and innovators that are actively developing plant-based products.

- support local food[67], prioritise 'import-replacing'[68] industries that build regional resilience and self-sufficiency.[69] [70]

We also advocate for the Government to develop a new comprehensive national land-use strategy that considers the recommendations set out by the Parliamentary Commissioner for the Environment in 2024[71]. This strategy should support a shift away from animal farming. It should include an integrated catchment approach to land-use planning, devolved decision-making to regional and local authorities with meaningful iwi partnership, and integrate with broader approaches to financial incentives such as pricing biogenic methane and removing forestry from the Emissions Trading Scheme. The Strategy will recognise the particular challenges faced by iwi with returned Crown forestry land, create specific pathways for Māori landowners to gain economic benefits from environmentally beneficial land uses and support iwi-led initiatives that align with te ao Māori business frameworks and kaitiakitanga principles.

The AJP believes Aotearoa's agricultural sector, and the way we use land, have huge potential to be transformed to better meet the needs of both humans, animals and nature. By embracing existing approaches and new technologies with regional control and determination, we can build viable economic alternatives to replace animal agriculture with a diverse portfolio of other products that go beyond an 'extractive industries' model towards high-value, regionally controlled production centered on local needs.

Key Objectives:

1. Identify the most promising region-specific economic opportunities for New Zealand's bioeconomy and land-use to shift away from animal farming, then implement steps to make this happen.
2. Develop a new comprehensive national land-use strategy with devolved decision-making that emphasises regional control of resources and financing and supports a shift away from animal farming.
3. Ensure tangible support for Māori landowners to exercise kaitiakitanga and rangatiratanga while achieving economic benefits.

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[67] Norberg-Hodge, H. (2024). *The Globalized, Industrialized Food System Is Destroying the World—We Urgently Need to Support Local Food Economies.* Resilience. https://www.resilience.org/stories/2024-11-05/the-globalized-industrialized-food-system-is-destroying-the-world-we-urgently-need-to-support-local-food-economies/?mc_cid=e66bf4c222&mc_eid=36d5595f33

[68] Witt, S. (2010). *The Grace of Import Replacement*. Schumacher Centre for new economics. [Essay]. https://centerforneweconomics.org/publications/the-grace-of-import-replacement/

[69] Alessandro Ford. (2024, November 11). *Want food security? Eat less meat, major report says.* Politico. https://www.politico.eu/article/food-security-eat-less-meat-says-major-report-common-agricultural-policy-cap-eu-farming/

[70] Morrison, T. (2024, November 12). *The case for feeding our 5 million first, before first tonne is exported.* Newsroom. https://newsroom.co.nz/2024/11/12/the-case-for-feeding-our-5-million-first-before-first-tonne-is-exported/

[71] Parliamentary Commissioner for the Environment. (2024). *Going with the grain: Changing land uses to fit a changing landscape.* This report has been produced pursuant to subsections 16(1)(a) to (c) of the Environment Act *1986.* https://pce.parliament.nz/media/qfxluadl/going-with-the-grain-changing-land-uses-to-fit-a-changing-landscape.pdf

4. Prioritise the development of local production for local needs, addressing the supermarket duopoly and their centralised approach, strengthening regional economies and reducing dependence on volatile export markets.

Become a leader in alternative proteins

The AJP believes Aotearoa can become a world-leader in alternative proteins. The Government should establish a National Centre for Alternative Proteins and dedicated funding for research, innovation and commercialisation.

New Zealand must position itself proactively to avoid the economic vulnerability that historically characterised its response to structural market changes, like the 1960s wool price shock.[72] Rather than treating the growing shift toward plant-based and cellular agriculture as a temporary disruption, Aotearoa should leverage its existing agricultural expertise, research capabilities and innovation systems to become a pioneer in this emerging sector. Funding for alternative proteins grew by 85% in 2024 in Asia-Pacific,[73]

New Zealand has a long heritage of agricultural innovation and a strong foundation in agricultural science and research. However at the current time much of this is being directed towards the ongoing exploitation of animals, for example through the development of vaccines, new genetic breeds and alternative feeds to reduce ruminant methane emissions.

There is an opportunity for New Zealand's science and research community to pivot towards plant-based solutions that are better for the environment, the climate and animals. Breaking free from the institutional inertia and path dependence that has historically favored traditional primary sector activities[74] noting New Zealand's institutional arrangements tend to favour the primary sector.[75]

The Vegan Society's Green Protein Report[76] highlights that New Zealand has significant untapped potential for plant protein production. According to the report, transitioning just 15% of animal farming land to plant protein crops could produce the same amount of protein while reducing land use, greenhouse gas emissions, and water pollution.

By making a decisive and well-resourced commitment to alternative protein development - including cellular agriculture, precision fermentation, and plant-based innovations - New Zealand can transform its agricultural comparative advantage into leadership in sustainable protein production.

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[72] Easton, B. (2023). *Learnings from The New Zealand Economic History of Shocks. Wellington: Productivity Commission.* Working paper 2023/02. Available from www.productivity.govt.nz. https://www.treasury.govt.nz/sites/default/files/2024-05/pc-inq-ier-brian-easton-2022-learnings-from-the-new-zealand-economic-history-of-shocks.pdf

[73] Mridul, A. (Nov 25, 2024). *APAC Agrifood Tech Funding Up by 38%, With India Reclaiming the Top Spot.* Green Queen. https://www.greenqueen.com.hk/asia-pacific-agri-food-tech-funding-investment-agfunder-report/?utm_source=green-queen-future-food-weekly.beehiiv.com&utm_medium=newsletter&utm_campaign=china-grants-regulatory-approval-for-animal-free-lactoferrin-future-food-weekly

[74] Easton, B as above

[75] New Zealand Productivity Commission. (2021). *New Zealand firms: Reaching for the frontier.* Final report. Available at www.productivity.govt.nz/inquiries/frontier-firms/ https://www.treasury.govt.nz/sites/default/files/2024-05/pc-inq-nzfrff-final-report-frontier-firms.pdf

[76] Vegan Society NZ. (2024). *The Green Protein Report*. https://vegansociety.org.nz/green-protein-report/

Cultivated meat and precision fermentation offer a transformative opportunity to create a food system that is kinder to animals, healthier for people, and far less damaging to the environment. By producing meat directly from animal cells, cultivated meat eliminates the need for factory farming, sparing billions of animals from suffering while reducing the risk of zoonotic diseases and antibiotic resistance. Precision fermentation allows us to create dairy and other animal-derived proteins without the environmental toll of industrial animal agriculture, slashing greenhouse gas emissions, water use, and deforestation. These innovations provide the same tastes and textures people love, but with dramatically lower impacts—offering a future where we can nourish the world without harming animals or the planet.

This transition demands more than incremental policy changes; it requires substantial investment in research and development, regulatory frameworks that enable innovation, and coordinated support for alternative protein startups and scale-ups. Unlike previous attempts at economic diversification that delivered "sub-therapeutic" results [77], the alternative protein strategy must be backed by material resources and clear policy frameworks to overcome the established institutional arrangements that favour traditional agriculture.

We propose to establish a new National Centre for Alternative Proteins to focus on these solutions - bringing together the best of New Zealand and international talent across science, academia, the farming industry and the policy and finance communities. This will be funded by redirecting the $400 million for R&D into agricultural climate solutions[78] away from animal-based towards plant-based solutions. It will be complemented by a dedicated Research, Innovation and Commercialisation Fund that supports New Zealand based innovators and scientists, and it will be targeted at solutions that have high economic potential for the country.

The National Centre will have a Māori Alternative Proteins Advisory Board with decision-making authority and a Māori Innovation Fund for iwi-led initiatives. Mātauranga Māori will be embedded in research, and co-investment models will enable iwi organisations to hold equity in ventures. Intellectual property protections and benefit-sharing frameworks will safeguard indigenous knowledge, while targeted programs will support Māori entrepreneurs and job creation in high-Māori-population regions.

These initiatives will work across the public and private sectors from early stage R&D through to scale-up and early commercial deployment. The National Centre will develop a roadmap of steps New Zealand should take across major opportunity areas and provide a range of grants and concessional finance support. It will also develop innovation clusters that can overcome the path dependence that has reinforced New Zealand's traditional economic trajectory and identify changes needed to the regulatory framework to remove barriers and create market demand for new products.

[77] Landfall Strategy Group. (2020). *Frontier firms: An international small advanced economy perspective.* https://www.treasury.govt.nz/sites/default/files/2024-05/pc-inq-nzfrff-frontier-firms-david-skilling.pdf
[78] Beehive. (The Official website of the New Zealand Government). (2024). *Agriculture to come out of the ETS.* https://www.beehive.govt.nz/release/agriculture-come-out-ets

There is huge potential for innovations in food technology to provide alternatives to animal products (as we have already seen with the popularity of oat milk), and even to provide 'real' animal products without farming animals. Whilst this must be done in an ethical way, and should not distract from the very real imperative to reduce consumption and animal farming now, it could make a real difference in reducing farmed animal numbers and animal suffering.

This alternative protein strategy represents a material commitment to economic diversification that acknowledges the institutional and historical barriers that have previously prevented New Zealand from adapting to structural economic changes before they become crises. With climate change advancing and almost fifty percent of New Zealand's greenhouse gases coming from agricultural emissions, moving away from animal agriculture now will help mitigate the size of the crisis. By ensuring Māori are true partners in this journey, the strategy can support rangatiratanga and economic self-determination while drawing on indigenous knowledge that may offer unique insights and innovations in the alternative proteins space.

Key Objectives:

1. Support New Zealand to become a world-leader in alternative proteins through a new National Centre and dedicated research, innovation and commercialisation funding.
2. Redirect existing agricultural R&D funding from animal-based to plant-based solutions.
3. Develop regulatory frameworks that enable rather than inhibit alternative protein innovation.
4. Create institutional structures capable of overcoming the historical inertia that has favored traditional primary sector activities.
5. Position New Zealand to proactively adapt to structural market changes rather than treating them as temporary disruptions.

4. Commissioner for Animals

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) believes that all animals in Aotearoa deserve adequate representation in Parliament, to ensure they are protected from exploitation and mistreatment.

To strengthen the voice of animals, we are advocating for the independent position of Commissioner for Animals to be established. Animal welfare is currently regulated by the Ministry for Primary Industries (MPI). This is the same Government department responsible for seizing export opportunities and overseeing agriculture productivity.[79] Decisions on animal welfare policies are being driven by industry stakeholders who are invested in profiting from the use of animals.

We believe this is detrimental to the rights and welfare of animals, as there is a clear conflict of interest, resulting in inadequate standards and an inability for animal welfare to be the primary concern in many areas.

Key Objectives.

1. Appoint an independent Commissioner for Animals who will have the authority to undertake a comprehensive review of the current system, and provide national leadership on animal protection.
2. Ensure adequate funding towards research and policy making that will improve animal well-being as backed by science.
3. Propose that the Commissioner for Animals has the power to hold MPI and other stakeholders accountable for the effective administration of the Animal Welfare Act 1999.
4. Ensure the Commissioner for Animals maintains independence from the executive Government to prevent conflicts of interest.
5. Ensure the Commissioner for Animals is equipped to make recommendations to improve enforcement of the Animal Welfare Act 1999 and to increase or add penalties where these are considered necessary.
6. Ensure adequate resources are appointed to organizations such as MPI and RNZSPCA to allow them to enforce the Animal Welfare Act 1999.
7. Ensure that the Ministry for Primary Industries updates the national Animal Welfare Strategy '2013',[80] and these updates include strenuous positive protections to be enacted.

<u>Animal welfare standards and known breaches</u>

The Animal Welfare Act 1999[81] outlines the needs of animals as follows:

- Proper and sufficient food and water.
- Adequate shelter.
- The opportunity to display normal patterns of behaviour.

[79] MPI stats
[80] Animal Welfare Strategy
[81] Animal Welfare Act Ref

- Physical handling in a manner which minimises the likelihood of unreasonable or unnecessary pain or distress.
- Protection from, and rapid diagnosis of, any significant injury or disease.

These basic needs must be met by law and oftentimes they are not,[82] hence the need for such a position as the Commissioner for Animals to be established. An independent Commissioner for Animals should be equipped to propose changes to legislation and enforcement where these basic requirements are being ignored or compromised.

Why do we need the Commissioner for Animals to be established?

New Zealand is the second largest exporter of animal products globally,[83] and while our Animal Welfare Act may seem adequate, the accompanying Codes, shaped by the animal agriculture industry, at times directly breach this Act. Because Aotearoa has such a large export industry, it is crucial that ethics and standards are upheld. As This industry is governed by stakeholders who do not have an impartial interest,[84] the rights and welfare of animals is often not prioritised. Simple things like the right to adequate shelter are being ignored and animals are suffering as a result.[85] New Zealand promotes animal welfare as our 'brand image' and prioritises animal welfare as part of our export story. It would seem that we are only capable of improving welfare standards

as a part of our export image but while there are animals being housed inappropriately, enduring inadequate shade and shelter, and being denied basic freedoms, we can not claim this image as truth.[86] The Commissioner for Animals would ensure a better outcome for all animals including farmed animals, animals in entertainment, companion animals, wild animals, and animals in research, testing and teaching.

Key legislative changes and priority issues for the Commissioner for Animals to address:

AJP will work towards legislation to repeal any codes of welfare that conflict with the requirements of the Animal Welfare Act 1999. The changes to legislation will be the framework the Commissioner for Animals utilises to ensure proper practices are enacted in animal spaces, such as animal agriculture and animals used for entertainment purposes. Along with multiple other organisations such as Save Animals From Exploitation 'SAFE',[87] Royal New Zealand Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Incorporated 'RNZSPCA',[88] the New Zealand Animal Law Association 'NZALA',[89] Helping You Help Animals 'HUHA',[90] and the New Zealand Anti-Vivisection Society 'NZAVS',[91] AJP firmly believes an independent commissioner who is solely responsible for improving the lives of animals, will help to create a future where animals are no longer being exploited or harmed. Animals should be allocated the right to no longer be

[82] Proof
[83] Global export stats
[84] Research about subpar standards
[85] Proof of inadequate housing and standard of care.
[86] Safe or SPCA link
[87] SAFE
[88] SPCA
[89] NZALA
[90] HUHA
[91] NZAVS

viewed as commodities or property. As living, sentient beings they deserve protection and conservation.

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NZALA_Farmed_Animal_Report
New Zealand Animal Welfare Strategy, Ministry for Primary Industries
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5. Compassionate Pound and Shelter Reform

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) advocates for a compassionate pound and shelter system where rehoming and no-kill are the national default, not the exception. We believe every dog is an individual with an inherent right to life, safety, and respect. Our policy tackles the root causes of overcrowding while transforming pounds into transparent, well-funded spaces dedicated to giving every dog the best possible chance of finding a home.

We challenge the current framework that allows thousands of dogs to be killed in the pound system each year. This is happening across councils with varying resources and policies, and largely out of public sight. In Auckland alone, 60%[92] of dogs entering the pound system between July 2024 and June 2025 were euthanised, that is 6,079 dogs. Behind every one of those numbers is an individual who deserved better.

AJP calls for urgent legislative and operational reform that places the best interests of each individual dog at the centre of pound policy. Every dog entering the pound system in Aotearoa deserves to be treated as an individual, not a statistic. Our goal is straightforward: fewer dogs killed, more dogs with a home.

Key Objectives:

1. Implement legislation that requires pounds to act in the best interests of the animals in their care.
2. Ban the use of bolt guns entirely, with no exceptions.
3. Mandate consistent, transparent public reporting, including the number of animals received and of that, how many are reunited with guardians, adopted or euthanised.
4. Strengthen reunification processes so guardians can quickly and easily locate missing dogs
5. Remove financial barriers to reclaiming dogs through flexible fee payment options
6. Shift from traditional temperament testing to behaviour assessment in calm, home-like foster environments
7. Enhance temporary animal housing conditions and capacity through increased funding and support for rehoming facilities
8. Formalise relationships with rescues and shelters
9. Foster community-led animal welfare initiatives across Aotearoa
10. Promote and invest in widespread, accessible desexing programmes
11. End breed-based euthanasia and ensure all dogs are assessed as individuals

[92] *Pūrongo ā-Tau Annual Report*. (2024). https://ourauckland.aucklandcouncil.govt.nz/media/0yjcq3gt/final_animal-management-annual-report-2024-2025_29-08-25.pdf

12. Ensure euthanasia is only ever used as an absolute last resort, and never on a healthy dog. Where it is required, it must be carried out in a way that minimises suffering.

Background

Aotearoa's pound system is facing significant and urgent challenges. Shelters and council-operated facilities are under pressure, resulting in large numbers of dogs being euthanised each year. Further to this, inefficient operating procedures contribute to the challenges. In Auckland alone, more than half of the dogs entering the pound system, between July 2024 and June 2025 were euthanised, creating widespread public fear that reporting a lost or wandering dog may result in its death. This erosion of trust demonstrates a system that is not functioning as it should for animals or communities. As a nation that regards dogs as beloved companions[93], it is critical that we address the failings of the current system and work collectively to achieve better outcomes.

AJP recognises that uncontrolled breeding is a primary driver of pound overcrowding. The sheer volume of incoming dogs currently hinders what can realistically be achieved in terms of individual welfare, enrichment, behaviour assessment, and rehoming. Because of this, AJP places strong emphasis on legislative and policy reform that mandates or facilitates widespread desexing, supported by adequate public funding. This includes public education initiatives that explain the consequences of failing to desex, the benefits of desexing, and promoting affordable/subsidised desexing schemes and how guardians can access these services. Addressing these upstream issues is essential to reducing intake pressures and preventing unnecessary euthanasia.

Causes

The rise in dog impoundments across Aotearoa reflects a combination of structural, social, and economic pressures. Interruptions to desexing initiatives during the COVID-19 pandemic[94], the

[93] Forrest, R., Awawdeh, L., Pearson, M., & Waran, N. (2023). Pet Ownership in Aotearoa New Zealand: A National Survey of Cat and Dog Owner Practices. *Animals*, *13*(4), 631. https://doi.org/10.3390/ani13040631

[94] OurAuckland. (n.d.). *Animal Management annual report reveals impact of COVID-19 pandemic*. OurAuckland. https://ourauckland.aucklandcouncil.govt.nz/news/2022/09/animal-management-annual-report-reveals-impact-of-covid-19-pandemic/

ongoing cost-of-living crisis, housing instability, and limited access to pet-friendly rentals all contribute to guardians surrendering or losing dogs.[95]

These factors demonstrate that the pound system does not operate in isolation. It sits within a wider context of social attitudes, economic pressures, and public policy gaps. While upstream issues such as desexing and responsible guardianship must be addressed urgently, immediate reform within pounds is also needed to ensure better welfare outcomes for dogs currently entering the system.

Under the Dog Control Act 1996,[96] councils follow a mandated protocol for managing impounded dogs, including efforts to contact guardians and a minimum holding period. If fees are unpaid or guardians cannot be reached, councils may rehome or euthanise the dog. Without systemic reform, this framework continues to produce poor outcomes in an environment already overwhelmed by high intake numbers and limited capacity. In March 2026, the government announced a review of the Dog Control Act to "crack down on roaming and uncontrolled dogs."[97] As of writing, the scope of the review is still to be determined but will include "looking at clauses which may be imposing barriers or resource pressure on councils, as well as penalties and consequences for non-compliant dog owners, desexing obligations, and stronger powers for council officers."

Community and Stakeholder Engagement

A sustainable and humane pound system depends on strong community involvement and shared responsibility. This requires public education about responsible guardianship, dog welfare, and the importance of desexing. It also requires active collaboration among all stakeholders, including guardians, breeders, veterinarians, trainers, shelters, rescues, iwi, community groups, educators, and government agencies.

High euthanasia rates undermine public confidence and discourage people from reporting wandering dogs, creating further risks to animal and community safety. Building trust through transparency, compassion, and consistent best-practice standards is essential. Community-led

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[95] *Preventing Pet Abandonment & Cruelty in NZ - Pet Rescue NZ*. (2025, December 24). Pet Rescue New Zealand. https://www.petrescue.org.nz/preventing-pet-abandonment-cruelty-in-nz/

[96] New Zealand. (1996). *Dog Control Act 1996* (Public Act 1996 No 13). New Zealand Legislation. https://www.legislation.govt.nz/act/public/1996/13/en/latest

[97] *Government orders review of Dog Control Act*. (2026, March 21). The Beehive. https://www.beehive.govt.nz/release/government-orders-review-dog-control-act

fostering, rehoming assistance, and safety initiatives can ease pressure on pounds and improve outcomes for dogs. AJP also supports measures that require guardians reclaiming their dogs to demonstrate responsible care, such as agreeing to desexing and meeting Animal Welfare Act standards.

Connection to Existing AJP Policies

Several existing AJP policies provide a foundation for pound reform:

- **Commissioner for Animals:** An independent Commissioner would provide impartial oversight across council pound practices and ensure animal welfare remains central to local government decision-making
- **Sentience and Legal Status:** AJP's advocacy for recognising animals as sentient individuals with inherent value directly underpins the case for treating every pound dog as someone, not something

Pawsitive Change Campaign

AJP's Pawsitive Change Campaign was born from the real stories of dogs like Robbie and Benny, who lost their lives in a system that should have saved them. Launched in 2024 and named in their memory, the campaign began with a clear, practical demand: that every council pound in Aotearoa must report consistently and transparently on the dogs in their care, including how many arrive, and how many are reunited, rehomed, fostered, or killed. That data is the foundation for everything else. Without it, we cannot know where the system is failing most, or where urgent support is needed. The policy proposals in this document build directly on the campaign's aims, and New Zealanders who want to add their voice can sign our petition at animaljustice.org.nz/pawsitive-change.

Our commitments

Improving outcomes for impounded dogs requires both system-wide reform and strengthened community responsibility. Pounds must adopt humane, modern practices, while guardians and the broader community must play a more proactive role in preventing abandonment and supporting rehoming.

AJP recommends replacing bolt guns with humane euthanasia methods that ensure rapid loss of consciousness and minimal distress, thereby reducing suffering for animals and trauma for staff. AJP also opposes breed-based euthanasia. A dog's life should never be ended on the

basis of how they look. Assessment must focus on individual behaviour and temperament, not breed assumptions.

Reunification processes should be strengthened through clear public-facing systems and varied communication methods to help guardians quickly locate missing dogs. Flexible reclaim fee payment options would help remove financial barriers that prevent guardians from reclaiming their dogs, reducing avoidable euthanasia.

A shift away from traditional temperament testing toward assessment in calm, home-like foster environments is also essential for accurately understanding a dog's behaviour and increasing successful adoptions. Establishing and funding foster networks would support extended holding periods, reduce overcrowding in pounds, and provide dogs with greater stability and wellbeing while awaiting rehoming.

Interim Measures

While broader legislative reform is developed, AJP calls for immediate action:

1. Require all councils to begin consistent public reporting on pound intake, outcomes, and euthanasia rates without delay
2. Issue urgent guidance banning bolt guns across all council-operated facilities
3. Establish subsidised emergency desexing access for guardians in financial hardship
4. Fast-track funding for foster network pilots in high-intake regions
5. Require councils to publish and follow a transparent rehoming pathway before euthanasia is considered for any healthy or treatable dog

Conclusion

AJP's proposed reforms aim to transform Aotearoa's pound system into one that is compassionate, transparent, and centred on the wellbeing of animals and communities. By addressing both the upstream drivers of overcrowding - such as uncontrolled breeding and barriers to desexing - and the immediate weaknesses in pound operations, Aotearoa can move toward a system where far fewer dogs are euthanised and far more experienced care, safety, and positive outcomes. These changes will strengthen public trust, reduce pressure on councils and rescue organisations, and ensure that dogs across the country are treated with the dignity and respect they deserve.

6. Cats, Conservation and Better Solutions

Why the Animal Justice Party opposes Predator Free 2050's inclusion of 'feral' cats

The Government has recently added 'feral'[98] cats to the Predator Free 2050 target species list. We oppose this. Not because we are indifferent to native wildlife, but because we believe the framing behind this decision is wrong, the actions and methods it encourages are cruel, and the evidence for its effectiveness in strengthening indigenous biodiversity is weaker than its proponents claim.

This is not a single-issue position. It reflects a consistent set of values that run across our entire policy platform: that all animals matter, that killing is not synonymous with conservation, and that Aotearoa can do better.

Furthermore, cats are Aotearoa's most beloved companion animal. The lives of many are enriched by being 'cat guardians' - especially those who are socially marginalised. The health and social benefits of cat guardianship are widely recognised. Aotearoa New Zealand has one of the world's highest rates of cat ownership, with 40% of all households sharing their homes with a companion cat.[99] The cultural affection which so many have for this species extends beyond the cat-guardian bond to encompass stray/community cats - there are well over 300 independent shelters and rescue groups across the motu[100] dedicated to rescue, rehabilitation and re-homing, as well as many more individuals who care for neighbourhood stray/community cats or managed desexed colonies, and very little social license even among the general public for the lethal management of unowned cats.

Three categories of cat were defined in the Companion Cat Code under the Animal Welfare Act,[101] and these definitions are accepted and used by DOC. These are:

- companion cats:
- community or stray cats (the term community has been widely adopted in recognition that these cats have their needs met by the collective community):
- feral cats:

Of these, only 'feral' cats were added to the PF2050 target list. The overwhelming majority of companion and community cats by definition live in cities and towns, where biodiversity values are negatively impacted by a suite of factors - inadequate and fragmented habitat, disturbance, constructed barriers and impervious surfaces, lights, reflective surfaces, widespread chemical use, traffic, etc, and therefore the potential of companion and community cats to impact on biodiversity values is low. And these cats are fed - only a small proportion of cats hunt effectively when they do not need to do so to survive, and in cities and towns available prey is

[98] Note on Terminology: While we acknowledge the definitions of companion, stray, and feral cats outlined in the Code of Welfare: Companion Cats, we intentionally reject the term 'feral' due to its embedded connotations of pestilence and aggression. Following modern animal relations frameworks (such as Donaldson and Kymlicka's Zoopolis), we prefer the term 'wild-living'. This distinction shifts the focus from a damaging biological label to a neutral observation of their lifestyle, recognising that these cats simply live independently outside human domestic society.

[99] New Zealand's unbreakable bond with pets: Insights from the latest Companion Animals NZ Report

[100] Shelter Register Aotearoa — Companion Animals New Zealand

[101] Code of Welfare: Companion Cats | NZ Government

not as likely to include taonga species nor is it likely to occur at a level which threatens the survival of these species.

Our position at a glance

We support a greater focus on the introduction of science-based, ethical methods to manage the genuine tension between introduced species, including cats, and indigenous species. We believe the primary driver of indigenous species decline in Aotearoa is habitat loss, not introduced animals, and that this must be honestly named and addressed proportionately.

What we believe: six policy pillars

1. **All animals matter**

Both indigenous and introduced species are sentient beings with a right to live unimpeded by human activities. Cats did not choose to come here. Humans brought them.

2. **Language shapes thinking**

We call for an end to unscientific, emotive and dehumanising terms to describe introduced animals that are not useful to us. Language that vilifies animals makes killing them easier to ignore. NZ has no hate speech laws pertaining specifically to animals - while animals cannot be hurt directly by the attribution of malice or intentional damage achieved by use of terms like ‘pest’, ‘invasive’, ‘stone-cold killer’, ‘utter killing machines’,‘killers for fun’, the effect is to demonise and to make killing and cruelty more acceptable.

3. **Lethal eradication is not conservation**

We oppose the use of 1080 poison on cats. Animal welfare scientists have found 1080 causes deaths averaging 9.5 hours of spasms and tremors. This is not humane. It is not acceptable.

4. **Innovation over violence**

Immunocontraceptives, in-ovo sex determination, gene drives are real, proven or emerging solutions. We question the belief that pre-human ecologies can/should be restored right across present day Aotearoa with its permanent and growing population and large scale agricultural economy, and that mainland eradication of introduced predator and perhaps also competitor species is achievable using available and even foreseeable technologies. We support a focus on strengthening and augmenting an adequately sized, world class reserve system encompassing multiple habitats above an unrealistic, overly-diffuse and ‘ad infinitum’ policy of eradication.

5. **Address the real driver**

Habitat loss is the primary driver of native species decline in Aotearoa. Focusing on introduced animals distracts from the human activities most responsible for ecological harm.

6. **Accountability and transparency**

An independent Commissioner for Animals and mandatory live cameras on traps would ensure that animal welfare decisions are made free from commercial or political pressure.

What we are calling for

Immediate steps

- A halt to any programme using 1080 poison or lethal trapping to kill cats under the Predator Free 2050 framework
- An immediate ban on recreational hunting of cats
- Mandatory live cameras on all traps used in conservation operations, to ensure real-time monitoring and accountability

Medium-term investment

- Government funding for research into immunocontraceptive programmes for free-living cats, building on models already used in other countries
- Expansion of desexing programmes, including government-subsidised or free desexing for low-income households, to reduce the number of cats entering the feral population in the first place
- Habitat fencing and ecosystem restoration as the primary tool for protecting vulnerable native species

Structural reform

- An independent Commissioner for Animals with genuine investigative powers, to ensure conservation decisions are made free from commercial or political influence
- Amendment of the Animal Welfare Act to extend protections to all wildlife, including introduced species, so that no animal can be subjected to extreme suffering for conservation purposes
- A shift in public funding away from lethal control and toward non-violent population management and habitat restoration

A note on complexity

We recognise there is a genuine tension here. Native species in Aotearoa evolved without land-based predators, and introduced animals do cause real harm. We do not dismiss that. But we do not accept that the only available response is mass killing. The choice is not between doing nothing and eradication. There is a third path, and this party exists to push for it.

We also recognise that many of the people who work in conservation care deeply about all animals. We want to work with them, not against them. The disagreement is about methods, not motivation.

Aotearoa can be a compassionate nation for all its animals, native and introduced alike. That is not a compromise. It is a higher standard.

7. Universal Veterinary Care - Ensuring Wellbeing for All Animals

The AJP is committed to establishing veterinary care as a fundamental right for all animals, recognising that access to medical treatment should never depend on their guardian's wealth or their status as companion, free-living, or wildlife. We acknowledge that the current system fails countless animals who suffer needlessly due to financial barriers, geographic inequities, and a veterinary workforce pushed to breaking point by commercial pressures and inadequate support. We propose comprehensive reforms to create a universal veterinary care system that prioritises animal wellbeing over profit, ensuring no animal is denied treatment because of economic circumstances.

The veterinary care crisis in Aotearoa reflects broader societal failures to value animal lives equally. Countless companion animals live in households struggling with the cost of living, where a sudden illness or injury forces impossible choices between veterinary bills and basic necessities. Meanwhile, injured wildlife, including our precious native species, suffer without treatment, and free-living cats and dogs continue breeding due to lack of accessible desexing services, perpetuating cycles of suffering that overwhelm rescue organisations and community groups.

This crisis is not inevitable, it is a direct consequence of treating veterinary medicine as a luxury commodity rather than essential care. The current system concentrates services in wealthy urban areas while rural and regional communities face severe shortages, leaving both animals and their human carers without local access to critical treatment. Veterinarians themselves suffer under this model, with crushing student debt, unsustainable workloads, and moral injury from having to deny care based on payment capacity driving concerning rates of burnout and mental health struggles within the profession.

The economic barriers are deliberately constructed. GST on veterinary services treats animal healthcare as discretionary spending, while limited university places and high fees create artificial scarcity that drives up costs and restricts workforce growth. Emergency procedures can cost thousands of dollars, forcing people to choose between insurmountable debt or euthanasia, while preventative care like desexing remains financially out of reach for many households, particularly in communities already facing economic hardship.

The connection to animal justice is fundamental and inseparable. Every animal who dies from a treatable condition because their carer couldn't afford treatment represents a failure of our society's values. Every injured kererū, kākā, or kiwi who suffers without veterinary intervention because there's no guaranteed funding for wildlife care reveals the hollowness of our claimed concern for biodiversity and our taonga species. Every free-living cat or dog who continues breeding because desexing is unaffordable perpetuates suffering across generations and threatens our native wildlife.

This policy also addresses the exploitation of veterinary professionals themselves. The current system transforms dedicated animal carers into gatekeepers of treatment based on payment,

creating profound moral distress that drives people from the profession. By removing financial barriers and adequately resourcing veterinary services, we create conditions where practitioners can focus on healing rather than billing, reducing the psychological harm that comes from denying necessary care to animals in their most vulnerable moments.

Beyond individual animals, lack of accessible veterinary care undermines community resilience and ecological health. Undesexed companion animal populations strain rescue networks, SPCA resources, and council pounds. Untreated injuries in free-living animals can lead to infection and disease spread that affects both domestic and native species. The absence of preventative care creates more expensive emergency interventions that people still cannot afford, perpetuating cycles of suffering, guilt, and animal abandonment.

The current model also perpetuates inequality between communities. Whānau in rural areas, small towns, and lower-income urban neighbourhoods face the greatest barriers, paying more to travel further for care that may not even be available locally. This geographic and economic discrimination means that where an animal lives determines whether they receive treatment, fundamentally contradicting any meaningful commitment to animal welfare.

The AJP believes that establishing universal veterinary care is an essential foundation for a compassionate society. It will save countless animals from preventable suffering, support carers in providing responsible care regardless of income or location, and create a veterinary profession where practitioners can fulfil their calling without the moral injury of profit-driven gatekeeping. This is not charity, it is recognition that animals' right to medical care should not depend on economic circumstance or postcode.

Key Objectives:

1. Establish Veticare - a universal veterinary care scheme providing government-funded treatment for all companion animals, with priority access for low-income households, superannuitants, and animal rescue workers
2. Remove GST from all veterinary services immediately, recognising animal healthcare as essential rather than discretionary spending
3. Create a national network of publicly funded veterinary clinics in underserved areas, with mobile services ensuring no animal is denied care due to geography
4. Fund comprehensive desexing programs for all companion and free-living cats and dogs to prevent suffering and protect native wildlife from predation
5. Establish dedicated wildlife veterinary services with guaranteed public funding for treatment of injured native and other animals
6. Transform veterinary education and workforce conditions by reducing financial barriers to training, improving mental health support, and providing incentives for practitioners in areas of greatest need
7. Deploy local animal ambulance services in every region for rapid transport of injured wildlife and vulnerable animals to critical care
8. Create a publicly accessible national register of financial support schemes, subsidised services, and payment options in te reo Māori and community languages
9. Implement strong regulations against price exploitation by corporate veterinary chains to protect independent practices and affordable community care

10. Establish community oversight through local animal welfare councils with power to direct resources to areas of greatest need and ensure meaningful representation from Māori, Pasifika and diverse communities

8. Getting Money Out of Politics - Restoring Democratic Equality

The AJP is committed to creating a democracy where all voices are heard equally, regardless of wealth or corporate connections. We acknowledge that money currently dominates our political system, giving wealthy industries, particularly those that exploit animals, vastly superior access to decision-makers compared to ordinary citizens and community advocates. We propose comprehensive reforms to eliminate financial advantages in politics, ensuring democratic participation is based on ideas and community support rather than economic power.

Unregulated lobbying creates a two-tier democracy where wealthy interests dominate decision-making while ordinary citizens and advocacy groups are shut out. The revelations in August 2025 about the then Fisheries Minister Shane Jones receiving over $100,000 from fishing industry donors while rolling back environmental protections illustrate this problem perfectly.[102] Companies like Talley's Group strategically split donations to avoid disclosure thresholds, while fishing baron Craig Boote admitted to spending $30,000 across parties before securing exclusive access to ministers.[103] This isn't democracy - it's a system where money buys policy outcomes.

Although Federated Farmers does not make direct political donations,[104] influence can flow through other channels. Andrew Hoggard's career path illustrates the concern: after nearly a decade in Federated Farmers leadership roles, including serving as president until May 2023, he joined ACT New Zealand the very next day.[105] Following the 2023 election, he was appointed Minister for Biosecurity and Food Safety, and Associate Minister of Agriculture (Animal Welfare, Skills)[106] and for the Environment, portfolios directly affecting farming and animal welfare. This revolving door between industry leadership and political office underlines the urgent need for reform: mandatory lobbying registers, cooling-off periods, and stronger transparency rules to ensure that public decision-making serves the wider public interest.
The connection to animal welfare is direct and profound. Industries that exploit animals (factory farming, commercial fishing, entertainment using animals) rely heavily on political influence to maintain harmful practices. By eliminating their financial advantages, we create space for evidence-based policy that considers animal welfare alongside human and environmental concerns.

When wealth can't buy political influence, policy debates focus on ideas, evidence, and community values rather than corporate interests. This creates conditions where animal welfare advocates can participate on equal terms with industry representatives, leading to policies that reflect genuine public concern for animals rather than industry profit margins.

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[102] https://theintegrityinstitute.substack.com/p/integrity-briefing-fishy-influence
[103] https://theintegrityinstitute.substack.com/p/integrity-briefing-fishy-influence
[104] https://theintegrityinstitute.substack.com/p/federated-farmers
[105] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Andrew_Hoggard
[106] https://www.beehive.govt.nz/minister/biography/andrew-hoggard

The AJP believes that getting money out of politics is a fundamental step that can be taken now to restore democratic equality and ensure all voices are heard. It will create policy-making processes that serve community wellbeing rather than corporate profits, reduce the political power of industries that exploit animals, and establish the democratic foundations necessary for building a compassionate society where the interests of all beings are properly considered.

Key Objectives:

Transparency & Electoral Finance

1. Limit total donations and loans from any single individual to a maximum of $30,000 per electoral cycle (or $10,000 per year) to curb excessive influence.
2. Reduce the threshold for publicly disclosing a donor's identity from $5,000 to $1,500 per year, preventing the “splitting” of donations.
3. Permit only New Zealand citizens or permanent residents registered to vote to make political donations, removing corporate/industry "entity" donations.
4. Remove the mechanism that allows large donations to be funneled anonymously through the Electoral Commission.

Lobbying & Institutional Integrity

5. Implement comprehensive lobbying transparency with real-time public disclosure of all meetings and communications between industry representatives and government officials.
6. Create meaningful cooling-off periods preventing the revolving door between industry leadership and political positions.
7. Establish independent oversight with strong enforcement powers to investigate breaches and maintain democratic integrity.
8. Protect public interest advocacy organisations from government retaliation while ensuring equal access to democratic processes.

Democratic Participation & Campaign Equality

9. Establish maximum membership fee caps for all political parties with low-income options, preventing wealthy parties from creating financial barriers while ensuring participation is based on community support rather than wealth.
10. Level broadcasting allocation between parties, distributing funding more evenly rather than concentrating it among established parties, and expand eligible spending to include TV, radio, digital ads, leaflets, print materials, direct mail, accessibility services, community media partnerships, shared infrastructure and small-party participation in debates.
11. Require at least 50% of public campaign funding to be spent with New Zealand businesses rather than overseas platforms.
12. Create infrastructure for small-party participation in televised and public debates.

9. Artificial Intelligence and Animal Welfare

Introduction

The Animal Justice Party of Aotearoa New Zealand (AJP) recognises that artificial intelligence (AI) is rapidly transforming how millions of animals are managed across farming, aquaculture and introduced species control in Aotearoa New Zealand. While AI technologies offer potential to improve animal welfare through enhanced monitoring and early disease detection, they also risk entrenching harmful practices and creating new forms of harm if deployed without adequate governance systems.

AJP does not endorse the continued expansion of animal agriculture. Any use of AI in these systems must demonstrate responsible development and genuine prioritisation of animal welfare and harm minimisation. We oppose AI technology systems designed purely for economic efficiency that treat animals as units of production rather than as sentient individuals with inherent value.

AJP calls for immediate integration of animal welfare and protection considerations into AI governance frameworks before harmful practices become economically entrenched and impossible to reform. The long-term policy direction of AI must prioritise transition away from animal farming, not the technological optimisation of it.

Context

The Scale of AI Deployment

AI technologies are already deployed across Aotearoa New Zealand's animal management systems at unprecedented scale. Over 400,000 cattle are currently managed using AI-powered virtual fencing systems, whilst millions more animals in dairy, beef, sheep, chicken, aquaculture systems and introduced species control are increasingly likely to be subject to AI-driven management decisions.

AI systems are being rapidly integrated into the management of these animals, making autonomous decisions about their welfare, health and lives.

Current AI applications include:

- Virtual fencing and herding: AI-integrated wearable technology using sounds and vibration to control animal movement, with systems learning and predicting individual behaviour patterns
- Slaughterhouse automation, Computer vision, machine learning and robotics for carcass grading, meat inspection, automated restraint, and cutting, optimising yield and throughput.
- Health monitoring: Computer vision and machine learning analysing gait patterns, body condition and behaviour to assess welfare
- Automated feeding and milking: AI-optimised systems managing nutrition and dairy production
- Aquaculture management: Machine learning for biomass measurement, feeding optimisation and water quality monitoring

- Introduced species control: AI-powered cameras in traps using species recognition, and autonomous drones identifying and poisoning target animals

The Regulatory Gap

The Animal Welfare Act 1999 was enacted before AI technology existed and contains no provisions for AI-driven animal management and welfare. This creates a critical regulatory time lag where technology is reshaping human-animal relationships faster than legislation and regulation can adapt.

Aotearoa New Zealand's AI Strategy (July 2025), positions agriculture as a key adoption sector but contains no animal welfare considerations. The accompanying Responsible AI Guidance for Businesses covers cybersecurity, privacy and intellectual property whilst omitting animal welfare entirely. The Ministry of Business, Innovation and Employment has been explicit that “unlike EU regulatory approaches, our approach is dispersed. The Government doesn't intend to put in place an overarching AI Act. AI risks should be managed in relevant legislation as they arise” (email correspondence Oct 2025).

This dispersed “light touch” approach is already being implemented in other sectors. 2025 changes to the Commerce Act, address AI-facilitated anti-competitive conduct, ensuring companies are liable for AI actions. Additionally, a Members Bill was introduced (2025) to amend the Harmful Digital Communications and Crimes Act 1961 to address AI-generated harms such as deepfakes. These examples confirm that rapid, targeted legislative response is possible.

Animal welfare requires the same urgency. Without explicit action to integrate welfare considerations into relevant existing Acts, AI governance will continue to treat animal welfare as a low-priority externality rather than a core consideration.

Without explicit regulatory requirements, AI systems will inevitably be designed solely for economic efficiency rather than animal welfare and protection. Market forces alone cannot ensure welfare and safety outcomes; only regulation can mandate that AI development prioritises animals' behavioural, physical and mental needs rather than subordinating them to economic and productivity metrics.

Case Study: Virtual Fencing Regulatory Lag

Virtual fencing technology demonstrates the pattern of regulatory lag that affects AI systems deployment. Despite operating commercially since at least 2020 and affecting hundreds of thousands of cattle:

- Circa 2021: The National Animal Welfare Advisory Committee (NAWAC) recommended safeguards for virtual fencing in its Code of Welfare Evaluation Report on Dairy Cattle, stating these "should have more generic application than only virtual fencing and apply to any future technology proposed for animal management"
- Early 2024: A petition called for a parliamentary inquiry into virtual fencing technology

- December 2024: Veterinarians for Animal Welfare Aotearoa announced development of a code of ethical conduct for virtual fencing, demonstrating industry concern whilst government action remained pending
- April 2025: The Petitions Committee recommended inclusion of guidance in the Code of Welfare: Dairy Cattle update
- July 2025: The government noted that virtual fencing presents "an opportunity to review the standards" but provided no timeline for implementation
- Late 2025: NAWAC's work programme plans to provide a revised recommendation, with no certainty about when actual regulatory guidance will be implemented

This five-year lag between commercial deployment and potential regulatory guidance illustrates the systematic failure to apply anticipatory regulation principles to animal welfare contexts, despite on-going advocacy by the Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (SPCA). Without proactive intervention, each new AI technology will follow this same pattern: commercial deployment, widespread adoption, entrenchment in industry practice, then belated regulatory consideration of animal welfare and safety.

Global Context and Market Pressures

Globally, most AI governance frameworks have overlooked animal welfare. The OECD's AI Principles and most national AI strategies focus exclusively on human-centred concerns such as privacy, bias, transparency, data integrity, accountability and safety.

However, a significant breakthrough occurred in July 2025, when the EU's General-Purpose AI Code of Practice explicitly listed “risk to non-human welfare” as a systemic risk, alongside threats to democratic processes, financial stability and environmental harm. This represents the first time a major jurisdiction has formally recognised that AI governance must consider animal welfare, achieved through successful advocacy by animal welfare organisations during the drafting stage.

Beyond the EU, Serbia's AI framework explicitly states AI systems “must be in line with the well-being of humans, animals, and the environment.” These examples demonstrate that inclusion of animal welfare in AI governance is both achievable and is increasingly being recognised as necessary.

The AI animal health market is projected to grow from approximately $1.4 billion in 2024 to over $8 billion by 2034, with the farmed animal sector expected to see the fastest growth. This rapid investment is occurring without systematic regulatory oversight of welfare outcomes, creating substantial risk that AI systems will entrench rather than improve current harmful practices.

Welfare Risks of Unregulated AI

- **Intensification of harmful practices**: AI technology makes existing harmful practices more efficient rather than more humane. It integrates best with intensive, cage-based systems that have the worst welfare conditions, enabling higher stocking densities and more intensive confinement, whilst appearing to ensure individualised care.

- **Economic prioritisation**: Data collection prioritises economic metrics over welfare indicators. AI systems optimise measurable parameters (e.g. milk yield, growth rate, feed conversion) whilst potentially missing qualitative welfare aspects such as emotional wellbeing, behavioural freedom and social relationships.
- **Reduced human oversight**: Fewer human caregivers enable larger-scale operations, removing human-animal relationships and reducing opportunities for animals to receive individualised attention and compassionate care.
- **Degraded human-animal relationship**: humans become algorithm supervisors rather than carers risking moral injury and loss of empathy. Sentient beings are viewed as data streams.
- **Technological dependency**: System failures could leave animals without care. Farms become vulnerable to hacking, sabotage and corporate espionage. Adverse weather conditions may impact camera-based systems.
- **Welfare washing**: AI systems create the appearance of individualised care whilst facilitating intensive systems. Companies can claim “precision welfare” or “AI-monitored health” whilst maintaining fundamentally harmful practices.
- **Automated lethal contro**l: AI-powered introduced species control technologies operate without direct human oversight of individual animal deaths, making life-or-death decisions autonomously. This raises serious ethical questions about delegating such decisions to algorithms designed for efficiency rather than compassion.

Economic Scale and Digital Divide

High AI technology implementation costs will create a digital divide where smaller operations cannot access technologies that larger commercial operations use for both efficiency and welfare monitoring. This risks creating a two-tiered system where animal welfare outcomes depend on economic scale rather than consistent regulatory standards, with larger operations able to demonstrate compliance through AI systems monitoring, whilst smaller farms lack resources for equivalent compliance systems.

The Window for Action

Despite AI technology deployment already underway across Aotearoa New Zealand's animal management systems, the window for proactive policy intervention still remains open. While systems already affect hundreds of thousands of animals, harmful practices have not yet become so economically entrenched that reform is impossible.

The government has demonstrated capacity for rapid legislative response when circumstances require it. In May 2025, Parliament passed the Wildlife (Authorisations) Amendment Bill under urgency to clarify authority for killing protected wildlife during development projects, responding within months to a High Court decision. This swift action demonstrates that regulatory speed depends on political prioritisation rather than legislative capacity.

Connection to Existing AJP Policies

Several existing AJP policies already provide a foundation for addressing AI systems and improving animal welfare:

- **Commissioner for Animals**: An independent Commissioner would provide necessary impartial oversight to manage inter-agency coordination on AI governance and ensure animal welfare and protection remains central to technological development
- **Sentience and Legal Status**: AJP's existing advocacy for abolishing the classification of animals as property, extended species coverage and defining sentience clearly in the Animal Welfare Act 1999 directly supports the need for AI systems to recognise animals as sentient individuals rather than productive units
- **Worker Rights and Safety**: Existing policies on Health and Safety at Work align with the recommendation to include animal welfare in automated system safety assessments
- **Transparency and Whistleblowing**: Policies protecting those who expose cruelty support the need for accountability in AI-managed systems

However, the unique challenges posed by AI systems require specific additional measures beyond these existing governance frameworks.

Key Objectives:

1. Amend the Animal Welfare Act 1999 to explicitly address AI applications affecting animals, including:
    - Specific welfare and protection provisions for AI systems in both farming and introduced species control contexts
    - Mandatory independent validation of AI welfare monitoring systems before commercial deployment
    - Requirements for human oversight alongside AI systems automation, ensuring that critical welfare decisions are not delegated entirely to algorithms
    - Mandatory welfare impact assessments for new AI technologies before deployment at commercial scale
    - Prohibition of AI systems that conceal, normalise or facilitate harm or cruelty
    - Clear accountability frameworks establishing who is responsible when AI management systems decisions cause animal harm or welfare failures
2. Update Codes of Welfare to include AI-specific guidance, beginning with the Code of Welfare: Dairy Cattle to address virtual fencing and AI-driven monitoring systems. All Codes should include:
    - Generic safeguards applicable to any future technology proposed for animal management
    - Standards for AI-enabled welfare monitoring to ensure systems genuinely improve outcomes rather than simply measure declining welfare more precisely
    - Requirements for validated welfare benefits before widespread adoption
    - Mandatory human competency and oversight requirements
3. Establish an animal-centred design framework for AI systems affecting animals, requiring that:
    - Systems must be explicitly designed for animal welfare, competence and protection, not merely economic efficiency
    - Design processes incorporate the Five Domains Model of positive animal welfare (Nutrition, Environment, Health, Behavioural Interactions, Mental State)

- Systems actively enhance animals' choice, control, variety, complexity and competence rather than simply monitoring their decline
- Welfare outcomes are validated independently before and after deployment
- Animals' behavioural, physical and mental needs are prioritised above productivity metrics
- Beneficial AI research and development is supported, including non-lethal, humane alternatives for managing human-wildlife conflict, and technologies that facilitate transition to plan-based food systems.

4. Create an Inter-agency AI-Animal Welfare Working Group chaired by the Commissioner for Animals, with representatives from agencies, including (but not limited to) the Ministry for Primary Industries, Department of Conservation, Environmental Protection Authority, Civil Aviation Authority and Commerce Commission, to:
    - Develop consistent guidelines and protection mechanisms across existing legislation and regulation
    - Coordinate enforcement protocols and information sharing between agencies
    - Apply One Welfare principles integrating animal welfare, human wellbeing and environmental considerations before AI systems are deployed
    - Report annually on AI systems developments, regulatory gaps and welfare outcomes
    - Monitor emerging AI technologies and assess their welfare implications before widespread deployment
5. Build regulatory capacity to assess and monitor AI technologies by:
    - Develop AI literacy programmes for Ministry for Primary Industries inspectors and Department of Conservation staff, enabling them to evaluate AI-based animal management systems
    - Create farmer and animal manager education programmes ensuring those who deploy AI can interpret outputs, recognise system failures and maintain appropriate human oversight
    - Develop assessment tools and criteria for evaluating AI-based welfare systems
    - Provide agencies with ongoing resources to understand rapidly evolving AI technologies and improve governance frameworks
6. Leverage existing legislative frameworks to address AI-animal welfare intersections immediately, without waiting for new legislation, including:
    - Privacy Act 2020: Extend data protection to animal-derived biometric data, ensuring commercial interests cannot exploit animal data without welfare safeguards and protection
    - Fair Trading Act 1986: Strengthen enforcement against misleading welfare claims, particularly "welfare washing" where AI systems monitoring is marketed as welfare improvement without evidencing genuine benefit to animals
    - Consumer Guarantees Act 1993: Ensure AI animal management systems meet fitness-for-purpose standards when welfare outcomes are promised
    - Resource Management Act 1991: Include animal welfare and protection in environmental impact assessments for AI systems
    - Health and Safety at Work Act 2015: Include animal welfare considerations in automated system safety assessments

    - Hazardous Substances and New Organisms (HSNO) Act 1996 and Agricultural Compounds and Veterinary Medicines (ACVM) Act 1997: Require welfare impact assessments for AI systems for all new technological interventions
    - Biosecurity Act 1993: Integrate welfare standards into AI-powered introduced species control programmes
    - Civil Aviation Act 1990: Mandate welfare protocols for drone-based animal operations, including both monitoring and lethal control applications
    - Wildlife Act 1953: Establish 'humane' standards for AI-enabled introduced species control technologies, recognising that automation does not eliminate legal and ethical obligations
    - Conservation Act 1987: Ensure the Department of Conservation's AI systems deployment prioritises conservation and welfare outcomes over operational efficiency
7. Establish transparency and accountability requirements for AI systems affecting animals:
    - Mandatory public reporting of AI deployment scale, including the number of animals affected and the types of systems used
    - Accessible data on welfare outcomes, system failures and interventions
    - Clear pathways for reporting, and addressing, welfare concerns related to AI systems
    - Protection for whistleblowers who expose AI systems-related welfare failures
    - Public registers of validated AI welfare management systems
    - Consolidated national statistics on introduced species control methods, kill numbers and welfare outcomes to enable comprehensive assessment of both traditional and AI-enabled systems
8. Prohibit AI applications that:
    - Enable increased stocking densities or more intensive confinement
    - Reduce human-animal contact below minimum welfare standards
    - Make autonomous lethal decisions without human oversight
    - Prioritise economic optimisation at the expense of animal welfare and protection
    - Conceal or normalise practices that would otherwise be recognised as harmful or cruel
9. Ensure AI governance frameworks address sentience comprehensively:
    - Expand explicit species coverage in animal welfare legislation to reflect current scientific understanding of sentience, including cephalopods, decapods, fishes and other invertebrates (as outlined in existing AJP policy on animal sentience and legal status)
    - Regulate AI systems affecting aquaculture and commercial fishing with the same rigour as terrestrial animal systems
    - Require that AI design processes acknowledge and respond to positive species-specific behavioural and cognitive needs

Interim Measures

While comprehensive legislative amendments are developed and implemented, AJP supports immediate actions to reduce harm:

10. Issue urgent guidance under existing legislation to all research facilities, farms and conservation operations using AI systems, requiring:
    - Immediate risk and animal impact assessments of current AI deployments
    - Enhanced human oversight protocols
    - Mandatory reporting of welfare failures related to AI systems
    - Suspension of AI systems that cannot demonstrate welfare benefits
11. Implement emergency protocols for deployed AI systems:
    - Mandatory backup systems ensuring animal care safely continues during technological failures
    - Clear escalation and resolution procedures when AI systems indicate welfare problems
    - Regular audits of AI systems decision-making to identify and rectify harmful patterns
    - Immediate intervention and resolution requirements when AI systems recommend actions contrary to animal welfare.
12. Fast-track regulatory capacity building by establishing an AI literacy programme for Ministry for Primary Industries inspectors and Department of Conservation staff, a rapid response team with expertise in both AI technology and animal welfare and interim assessment tools for currently deployed AI systems.
13. Prioritise virtual fencing regulation as a test case for broader AI governance:
    - Implement NAWAC's recommended safeguards immediately through the Code of Welfare: Dairy Cattle (on the assumption they are reasonable in relation to the code of ethical conduct developed by the Veterinarians for Animal Welfare Aotearoa)
    - Require independent welfare validation of existing virtual fencing systems
    - Establish clear standards for appropriate use, system maintenance and animal conditioning
    - Prohibit use near milking sheds and in situations where animals cannot retreat from stimuli
14. Conduct comprehensive AI systems deployment mapping across all animal management sectors to identify the current scale and scope of AI systems use, assess the welfare risks, prioritise regulatory intervention and establish transparent baseline data for measuring regulatory effectiveness.
15. Establish interim consultation processes ensuring:
    - Animal welfare organisations are consulted on AI technology development and deployment
    - Welfare and protection considerations are integrated into industry AI systems adoption decisions
    - Public input is sought and integrated for AI technologies affecting animals
    - Affected communities, including farmers and conservation practitioners, contribute to ongoing regulatory development.

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10. Companion Animal Bereavement and Parental Leave

The AJP is committed to recognising the profound emotional bonds between humans and companion animals, acknowledging that these relationships provide immense psychological, emotional and social benefits that mirror many aspects of human family connections. We acknowledge that current employment law fails to recognise the grief and care needs associated with companion animals, forcing people to use sick leave or holiday entitlement during some of their most vulnerable moments.

We propose establishing statutory rights to bereavement and parental leave for companion animal guardians. Leave entitlements should be flexible blocks that employees can use to care for who they consider family, whether parents, children, or companion animals. This approach avoids additional administrative burden for businesses while reflecting the reality of modern family life.

Half of pet owners say their animal is a member of the family, equal to humans, reflecting the deep emotional connections that have developed over thousands of years of co-evolution. Anyone who has ever loved a pet knows: they're not "just animals" - they're family. They're the wagging tail that greets us after a hard day, the purring companion during late-night work sessions, and the loyal friend who never judges our worst moments.

Some forward-thinking employers have already recognised this reality. Google, Starbucks, United Airlines and Walmart have embraced a so-called "pet-conscious workplace",[107] while pet ownership surged during the pandemic,[108] and more workplaces have become pet-friendly.[109] The concept of "pawternity leave", time off (paid or unpaid) for staff who have recently brought home a pet, is gaining recognition internationally.[110]

Currently, pet leave isn't a legal right, but some businesses offer it.[111] This creates inequality where workers in progressive companies receive support while others must navigate grief and companion animal care using inappropriate leave categories or risk job security. The absence of statutory rights means many people cannot properly grieve the loss of beloved companions or adequately care for newly adopted animals during critical bonding periods.

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Policy Framework

- **Bereavement Leave**
    - Up to 5 days paid leave available as a single entitlement for use following the death of a close human family member *or* a companion animal.
    - Flexible timing to cover funerals, tangihanga, memorials, veterinary appointments, or grieving.
    - Self-declaration only, no burdensome paperwork.
- **Parental (“Pawternity”) Leave**
    - Up to 3 days paid leave available when a new family member joins the household, whether a baby or an adopted companion animal.
    - Additional unpaid leave (up to 2 weeks) available for animals with special needs or trauma histories.
- **Emergency Care Leave**
    - Employees may take reasonable time off to respond to urgent medical emergencies, end-of-life decision-making, or intensive care needs - for human or animal family members.

This policy reflects our core belief that recognising the sentience and emotional value of animals creates a more compassionate society overall. When we acknowledge the grief people feel for companion animals, we validate the emotional lives of those animals and reinforce that all beings deserve consideration and respect.

The AJP believes that establishing companion animal bereavement and parental leave is a compassionate step that can be taken now to support the millions of New Zealanders who share their lives with animal family members. This policy will reduce workplace stress, improve employee wellbeing, and strengthen a compassionate culture in Aotearoa New Zealand.

Key Objectives:

1. Establish statutory bereavement leave (up to 5 days) for family members, human or nonhuman animals
2. Create "pawternity leave" entitlement of up to 3 days for new family members, including companion animals
3. Extend emergency leave provisions to cover urgent care for both human and nonhuman family
4. Ensure leave entitlements apply equally to all recognised forms of family life.